

This case study is an exploration of televisual place, of Orange County, California, and three popular U.S. shows set therein: *The OC*, *Laguna Beach: The Real Orange County*, and *The Real Housewives of Orange County*. Place is a meaningful experience in the world, and it is made through a unique intersection of social processes. It is much more than the material embodiment of social processes in a particular location, it is also an amalgam of memory, emotion, and imagination. Places of the media fit this description. More than just re-presentations of reality, mediated places are an inextricable part of our daily lives, and directly engage the processes

of place-making by affecting our perception, senses, and subjectivity. These three Orange County based series are used to demonstrate how production techniques contribute to the place-making process and how this process continues and culminates with audience engagement. The use of landscape images, the concept of emotional realism, and reality TV's claim to the real are explored for their role in the televisual place-making process. Audience surveys and the phenomenon of TV-induced tourism demonstrate the importance of televisual places to viewers. This book seeks to prove that mediated places, especially as seen on TV, matter.

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Place, Television, and the Real Orange County

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Geographie



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Ann Fletchall / Chris Lukinbeal / Kevin McHugh

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Media Geography -2

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Kevin McHugh

Place, Television, and the Real Orange County

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MEDIA GEOGRAPHY AT MAINZ

Edited by

Anton Escher
Chris Lukinbeal
Stefan Zimmermann

Volume 2

Ann Fletchall / Chris Lukinbeal / Kevin McHugh

Place, Television, and the Real Orange County



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Geographers usually see themselves in a tradition of Alexander von Humboldt and we would like to highlight his position that everything in our world is inter-dependent. Deriving from that assumption geography has to be seen as an unlimited science, a discipline that knows its borders but has none.

Anton Escher, Chris Lukinbeal and Stefan Zimmermann,
Mainz, January 2008

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CHAPTER 1

PLACE-MAKING AND THE MEDIA

Manhattan, to *Sex and the City* fans, is a collection of fashionable bars, restaurants, busy sidewalks, and iconic skyscrapers. Los Angeles, to viewers of *Beverly Hills 90210* or *The Hills*, is "a simple equation of sunshine, beaches, palm trees," trendy boutiques, and nightclubs (STENGER 2001, 63). To the millions who watched *Dallas*, it is to this day a city of oil money and big hair (CURRY 2004). Places created by television are more-than-real and larger than life. Although fragmented and exaggerated, the places television creates are more beautiful, more glamorous, and even more grotesque than residential experience, a vacation, or a business trip might lead one to believe. "It is not the allure of the real New York City that gives it such prominence," affirm SADLER and HASKINS (2005, 213), "but rather the appeal of the absolute fake version." Some places exist not as lived in, walked through, worked on, or "been there," but as they are seen on-screen. The evocative images that film and television produce create place; mediated place in simulated and stimulating forms is constitutive of contemporary experience.

Orange County, California, is a locale that is experienced in myriad ways. In our hypermediated culture, a neat and tidy distinction between direct and indirect (or mediated) experience cannot be sustained. Place-making and meanings are irretrievably bound up in media, including the twin towers of visual media: film and television. In exploring three popular television shows, we argue that the media, specifically television, plays a significant, yet overlooked, role in place-making.

Until recently, Orange County had limited exposure in film and television, with few movie roles and nary a *Sex and the City* to its credit. With the broadcast of three highly popular TV shows bearing its name, the County of Orange has been transformed from lackluster suburbia to televisual star. These shows—*The OC*, *Laguna Beach: The Real Orange County*, and *The Real Housewives of Orange County*—aided in transforming Orange County into the new and hip "OC," a glamorous spectacle, a more-than-real simulation. The transformation of Orange County into "the OC" illustrates how television moves beyond representing or simulating place by becoming an active participant in place-making.

This book fills a lacuna in geographical research: the role of television in place-making. In this introductory chapter we elaborate mediated place as process. We position the study within media studies in geography and articulate our perspective through an interrogation of key issues in place and representation. En

route we illuminate the optical unconscious, animate place, implode the real/reel binary, tarry on the textual metaphor, and travel to televisual place as simulacra.

MEDIA GEOGRAPHIES: FAST FORWARD TO THE OPTICAL UNCONSCIOUS

Early forays in media geographies focused on mimetic and pedagogic qualities of film (MANVELL 1956; KNIGHT 1957), and pioneering work by Eugene WIRTH (1952) examined relationships between narrative, space, and place in film. It was not until the "cultural turn" in the late 1980s that geography began a serious engagement with visual media. Geographers in this period were initially attracted to visual media because this provided a way to examine non-material culture and representations. Both AITKEN and ZONN (1994) and NATTER and JONES (1993) make this argument in contending that geographers have traditionally emphasized material conditions over representations, set within the larger debate over "traditional" versus "new" cultural geography (COSGROVE 1993; DUNCAN 1993; JACKSON 1993; PRICE and LEWIS 1993a, 1993b). This debate focuses on whether "traditional" cultural geography, modeled after Carl Sauer and the Berkeley School, privileged material conditions and "fieldwork" to the extent that non-material cultural forms and representations were neglected.

Prior to the cultural turn, humanistic geography's engagement with media focused primarily on literature (MOORE and GOLLEDGE 1976; SALTER and LLOYD 1976; POCOCK 1981a, 1981b; MALLORY and SIMPSON-HOUSLEY 1987) and art (REES 1973; KING 1990; TUAN 1990), in part because film and television were viewed as forms of mere entertainment. By ignoring such a wealth of information, geography appeared to be an elitist pursuit wherein popular culture was not deemed worthy of inquiry (GOLD 1974; BURGESS and GOLD 1985).

Since these early forays into media, numerous books have engaged geographical implications of media (BURGESS and GOLD 1985; ZONN 1990; AITKEN and ZONN 1994; CLARKE 1997; SHIEL and FITZMAURICE 2001; CRESSWELL and DIXON 2002; JANCOVICH, FAIRE, and STUBBINGS 2003; LUKINBEAL and ZIMMERMANN 2008; ADAMS 2009). In these books, as well as in journal articles, cinema and space has garnered far more attention than television and place, which is surprising given the fact that in 1990 BURGESS outlined an agenda for media research in geography which identified the importance of television.

Our goal is to demonstrate ways in which television creates and perpetuates meaningful experiences vis-à-vis place. To do so we investigate how the techniques that form televisual landscapes structure narrative content and affect active engagement with place. These techniques, or narrative conventions, work to situate place within a landscape that promotes geographic realism, an effect that appropriates social-spatial meanings to a particular locale. Geographic realism works to authenticate place by grounding the fictional narrative to a "real historical place" (HIGSON 1984, 3). Geographic realism seeks to build and reinforce the

social and spatial meanings of place. Geographic realism functions fully within the realm of optics, or as HIGSON (1987, 10) explains:

Television constructs a sense of a public sphere of knowledge, action, events, and people, out there, separate from the viewer who observes from the private sphere of home. But at the same stroke, television constructs the public sphere *as a series of images*, in which the viewer *does* participate, precisely as observer (HIGSON 1987, 10).

Place-making requires more than mere observation and a voyeuristic engagement with the aesthetic production of televisual place. As BRUNO (2002, 16) notes, an optical model of filmic space reduces spectatorship to a fixed, disembodied gaze which is unfit "to account for the types of displacement that are represented, conveyed, and negotiated in the moving image." Optical models are important in understanding the power of the gaze as it naturalizes ways of seeing. A focus on optics, however, limits the inquiry to socially constructed meanings found within television. Film and television produce both a visual aesthetic and an "anti-aesthetic interruption" (DUBOW 2004, 277) that engages the optical unconscious. The optical unconscious "lies below the formal level at which the visual might begin" (DUBOW 2004, 266). In other words, we do not see vision but experience it through corporeal experience (DOEL and CLARKE 2007). The optical unconscious accentuates

the conviction that the world is not a ready-made that can be counted on and reflected upon. It is an event, a happenstance, a taking place. What takes place, however, is not arbitrary, as eventfulness is increasingly *anticipated* by a plethora of more or less imperceptible 'performative infrastructures' (DOEL and CLARKE 2007, 898).

DUBOW (2004, 270) argues that the optical unconscious is "[s]tructured in mobility, it designates a space that eludes legibility, or rather it produces a space in which the visual struggles to 'take place.'" Spectators are not motionless subjects chained to identification with the camera's gaze; rather, they are engaged in a "kinetic affair" that exceeds the representation presented (BRUNO 1992, 115). This kinetic affair links the pleasures of spectatorship to the feeling of dynamic motion, which is generated by the camera's wandering eye. This pleasure differs from the idea of the immobile subject experiencing pleasure as a voyeur. We are not passive vessels experiencing voyeuristic pleasure; rather, we explore the presentation as tourist. Exploration is a kinetic moving gaze which transverses the televisual world as an extension of our world. This anti-optical engagement "is a haptical mobilization, an (e)motional journey that leads us to question our identity and its relation to values, experiences, and knowledge" (LUKINBEAL and ZIMMERMANN 2008, 21; cf. BRUNO 2002). The optical unconscious "provokes tension, contestation, and emotional responses because it does not separate subject (the viewer) from object (the content and form of the visual/audio)" (LUKINBEAL and ZIMMERMANN 2008, 21). Where the techniques of geographic realism work to construct a landscape in which places have meaning, the optical unconscious produces an emotional realism that breaks down the barriers between subject and object, allowing for place-making to occur. BRUNO (2007, 23–4) describes cinema as an "art of memory":

[F]ilm itself draws memory maps. In its memory theater, the spectator-passenger, sent on an architectural journey, endlessly retraces the itineraries of a geographically localized discourse that sets memory in place and reads memories as places. As this architectural art of memory, filmic site-seeing ... embodies a particular mobile art of mapping: an *emotional* mapping.

Where place has been traditionally defined by its absolute location within a global graticule, or in relation to other places in a relative space, newer theorizations conceive place as an ongoing process, continually practiced and performed (MASSEY 2005). The traditional definition of place limits television to representing place, while the latter challenges us to reconsider the role of visual media in the place-making process.

A PLACE FOR TELEVISION

The emergence and success of television as a mode of reception can be partially linked to the high rate of family formation following World War II in the United States. SPIGEL (1992) suggests that the growth of television in post-World War II was, in part, a cultural return to family values, neighborhood bonding, and community participation. Urban flight and rapid suburbanization in the 1950s spatially characterized this sociological change. Suburbanization and the advent of television forced a redistribution of consumption sites. SPIGEL (1992) links the rise of television to the values and ideology associated with suburban life. She argues that "suburbia emerges as a conformist-oriented society where belonging to the neighborhood network was just as important as the return to family life" (SPIGEL 1992, 86). Television aided in the re-visioning of this morality by providing a means through which people could safely negotiate spatial boundaries between the public and private sphere. Television provided a form of access to the sphere of the public within the private home. Television promised "familial bliss" which was "wholesome" in that it was white, middle class, and heterosexual (SPIGEL 1992, 192). Television purified public space by standardizing and naturalizing the "American experience." In short, television provided unity through cultural hegemony.

Watching TV remains one of America's favorite pastimes, and television is certainly one of the most ubiquitous of mediums. In addition to the television screens which populate airports, sports bars, and health clubs, the average American home has more TV sets than people. During the 2006–2007 television season, American households watched, on average, eight hours of TV per day (Nielsen Media Research 2007). TV is, undeniably, a significant part of our lives.

Cinema has received much more attention in scholarly circles than television. This is due, in part, to the smaller and squarer TV screen and the fact that TV shows are shorter and interrupted by commercials, often failing to command the full attention of viewers (HIGSON 1987). While movies are better conveyors of sense of place, owing to a superior aspect ratio for depicting landscapes, television's episodic nature strengthens its place-making power. As opposed to a singular movie seen once or perhaps a few times at most, viewers make weekly

visits to the world of the TV show. If the show proves successful, these visits may extend over a period of years. The structure of a TV series allows *more* time for place to be created and for viewers to develop attachments to characters and become emotionally involved in their lives. Televisual place displays an aura of familiarity. The act of viewing can become a highly anticipated event, with escapes to the televisual world being an integral part of one's weekly routine.

PLACE AND TELEVISION

We move away from fixed and concretized notions in favor of a more animated view of place as gatherings, encounters, events, entanglements (THRIFT 1999; MASSEY 2005). Place is constantly produced and reproduced in a world in movement, open to change, mediation and contestation (CRESSWELL 2004). Place is a calling forth, a putting to task through practice and performance, akin to what Tim INGOLD (1993) calls a *taskscape*. An animated conceptualization does not imply that place is without structures, but rather that structures are emergent in ongoing practices and performances which make place meaningful. Place is a gathering—a gathering of things, thoughts, memories and emotions in particular configurations (ESCOBAR 2001).

In his treatise on television, ADAMS (1992, 118) conceives of place as a “system in which symbolic interaction among persons occurs (a social context), and a nucleus around which ideas, values, and shared experiences are constructed (a center of meaning).” ADAMS (1992) argues that television provides a social context that unites a great number of people around a common experience or event such as the Superbowl or the World Cup. Television also produces cultural symbols and meanings through the introduction and popularization of, say, Lady Gaga. In ADAMS' (1992, 119) words, “insofar as people experientially inhabit it and relate to other persons through it or within it,” then television is a place, or more precisely a “gathering place” (ADAMS 1992, 117). Televisual gathering places are not universal, but rather are contested domains in which meaning, power and knowledge are naturalized and contested. MASSEY (1994, 154) similarly suggests that place is the particular intersection of networks of social relations, movements and communications. For both MASSEY and ADAMS, places are not spatially defined areas with distinct boundaries, but are “articulated moments in networks of social relations” (MASSEY 1994, 154).

Meeting or gathering place has many forms; it cannot be restricted to the material embodiment of social processes in a particular location. Place is an expression of emotional resonance, a product of our imagination, memories and image-events from television and cinema. André MALRAUX (1967) describes place as a *musée imaginaire*:

We ... carry around with us a *musée imaginaire* in our minds, drawn from experience (often touristic) of other places, and knowledge culled from films, television, exhibitions, travel brochures, popular magazines, etc. It is inevitable ... that all of these get run together (HARVEY 1989, 87; cf. JENCKS 1984).

According to the art historian Denis HOLLIER (1998, 64), MALRAUX's conception is "a museum conceived in terms of cinema."

Televiſual places are becomings threaded with feelings and emotion. Whereas space is often conceived in objective fashion, place speaks to meaningful experience in the world. As TUAN (1977, 4) argues, "places are centers of felt value." BRUNO (2007, 38) takes TUAN's argument one step further in positing that cinema and television, through moving images, are an "intimate exploration – a screen of personal and social, private and public narratives" (BRUNO 2007, 38). It is thus a

map of intersubjective views. A haptic architecture. A topophilic affair. A place for the love of place. A site of close picturing for undistanced *emotion*. A museum of emotional pictures (BRUNO 2007, 38).

Media are an indispensable component of place, contributing to how we experience worlds, not as universal, but differentiated by social, cultural and subjective processes that make place meaningful (RELPH 1976). In humanist terms, the essence of place cannot be defined by absolute location or functions, but rather through human existence and immersion (RELPH 1976). Places involve a "concentration of our intentions, our attitudes, purposes, and experience"; they are "the point of departure from which we orient ourselves in the world" (RELPH 1976, 43). Place is

a way of seeing, knowing, and understanding the world. When we look at the world ... we see attachments and connections between people and place. We see worlds of meaning and experience (CRESSWELL 2004, 11).

In television and cinema,

places are used as wax, they bear the layers of a writing that can be effaced and yet written over again, a constant redrafting. Places are the site of a mnemonic palimpsest ... places live in memory and revive in the moving image ... Mechanically made in the image of wax simulacra, the projected strip of celluloid is the modern wax tablet. Not only the form but the *écriture* is reinvented in film's own spatial writing, décor, and palimpsestic architectonics, as well in the spectatorial promenade. The loci of the art of memory bear the peculiar wax texture of a filmic "set" – a site of constant redrawing, a place where many stories both take place and take the place of memory (BRUNO 2007, 21–22).

IS TELEVISUAL PLACE A REPRESENTATION?

In geography there is a normative belief that television and cinema are representations of some ontologically stable reality awaiting our exploration. As AITKEN and DIXON (2006, 327) explain, "we can no longer talk of film representing, or mimicking, reality because we can no longer assume that there is a single reality waiting out there to be filmed." They go on to argue that while the "camera records mass and motion ... the 'nature' of the objects that appear on screen is firmly located in the social realm wherein meaning is ascribed to them."

We can ascribe two competing theories about the role of place within television and cinema. On the one hand, the normative belief ascribes to a logic wherein television and cinema are representations and thus can be assessed by their accuracy or success in providing “unmediated” access to the real world (MANVELL, 1956; KNIGHT, 1957; HARVEY 1989). Exemplary of this approach is HARVEY’s (1989) use of film in illustrating the condition of postmodernity. He sees certain films as “brilliant portrayals ... of the conditions of postmodernity, and in particular the conflictual and confusing experiences of space and time” (HARVEY 1989, 322). HARVEY observes film merely as an apparatus that projects pictures in motion which reduces “the complex stories of daily life to a sequence of images upon a depthless screen” (HARVEY 1989, 322). Because of this, no film “has the power to overturn established ways of seeing or transcend the conflictual conditions of the moment” (HARVEY 1989, 322). HARVEY perceives film as capable of only mirroring the conditions of lived experience (AITKEN and ZONN 1994). As he puts it, “in the final analysis” film is “a spectacle projected within an enclosed space on a depthless screen” (HARVEY 1989, 308). For HARVEY, material conditions should always be privileged over representations. Here, representations of place are tied to the re-presentation of absolute locales where mediated place is no more than a vicarious or secondhand experience (LUKINBEAL and ZIMMERMANN 2008).

A second view holds that place is a fusion of the actual and virtual (or mediated), as the actual and virtual are two interrelated dimensions of the real (MARTIN, 2000). This perspective finds expression in varying ways in cultural and geographical thought, including SOJA’s (1996, 11) influential work articulating a geographical imaginary as a “thirdspace” that is “simultaneously real and imagined.” Following the logic of SOJA, HANNA (1996, 638) argues that place is “always-already a representation.” His examination of Roslyn, Washington, – which played “fictional” Cicely, Alaska, in television’s *Northern Exposure* – demonstrates how a particular locale is a fusion of the real and imagined. In *Northern Exposure*, Roslyn constitutes the real, while Cicely is the imaginary; the locale is mutually constituted by both, as well as by the cultural history of the town. HANNA (1996) argues that this place is paradoxical in that Roslyn and Cicely can never wholly be constituted as either real or imagined because all places have a representational legacy that extends beyond practices that produce their current configuration. Prior to its notoriety as Cicely, Roslyn’s built form and identity was tied to its history as a company mining town, its revitalization as a quaint historic site, and subsequent evolution to vacation spot for Seattle-ites. Roslyn’s identity is bound to these legacies. The creation of televisual Cicely, from Roslyn, adds another layer to the representational mélange that is this place. In HANNA’s (1996, 642) words: “Roslyn, as a place, is just as much a representation as Cicely is material.”

HANNA’s (1996) essay on Cicely/Roslyn seeks to engage place as mutually constituted by its representational legacy and its material landscape. Its role as Cicely added a layer to Roslyn’s current form, including *Northern Exposure*-related gift shops and remnants from the set, but HANNA (1996) does not consider

the televisual place that *Northern Exposure* has created. We see that Cicely is a part of Roslyn, but what of the meaningfulness of Cicely's Alaska?

While HANNA offers one way to address how place-making incorporates the real and imagined, it remains cast within the real/reel binary and thus elaborates only how a morphological approach can be applied in understanding televisual place as a representation. A morphological approach requires the stripping away of layers to uncover the various meanings inscribed in a locale. As AITKEN and DIXON (2006, 329) note:

This is not necessarily articulating landscape [or location] as a passive stage upon which culture struts its stuff. Rather, the morphology of landscape is seemingly depicted accurately in the ways it actively connects with culture. In this interpretative gambit, culture is a factor and landscape is a medium.

As such, belief in the reel/real binary is reinforced as cultural meaning is naturalized and inscribed onto an ontologically stable locale, rather than seeking to expound upon the meaningful processes in place-making. Furthermore, POORE and CHRISMAN (2006, 513) argue that the

landscape-as-layers metaphor demonstrates how a discursive practice, which originated as a leap in scientific logic, can interact through time with the agencies of people, institutions and technologies to enforce certain ways of seeing and talking about the landscape.

These ways of seeing reinforce the idea that meaning is inscribed onto a pre-given landscape or location. COSGROVE (1989) similarly deploys the landscape-as-layer metaphor, reinforcing the morphological approach where different layers embody different symbols and meaning. The problem with the layered metaphor is that it "carries the implication that the way to uncover the most basic level of human beings' practical involvement with their environs is by stripping these layers away" (INGOLD 1993, 171). Rather than stripping away layers, or decoding sequential deposits of meaning, cinematic and televisual landscapes and places are never complete; they are performative becoming.

TUAN (1991, 690–691), too, recognizes the influence of evocative literature upon the "real world" but maintains the binary distinction between real and imagined places:

221B Baker Street [of Sherlock Holmes fame] is more vividly present to some Londoners than are the apartment homes of their maiden aunts, and more real by far to tourists than are the hotels they temporarily occupy ... [London] can seem unreal precisely because it is so thoroughly transformed by the literary imagination ... [I]t goes without saying that a literary person's sense of reality is more thoroughly penetrated by what he or she has studied and absorbed.

The same might be said of the reality of an earnest television watcher; rather than by words from a novel, it is a reality permeated with images from the screen. Take for example the Manhattan Television Tour, which TORCHIN (2002) presents as an experience which thrives on blurring the boundary between the televisual and "real" worlds. On the tour, guests are shuttled around the city to glimpse what would otherwise be ordinary New York buildings, but for their use in establishing exterior shots of popular TV shows (stops include the *Friends* apartment building

and *The Cosby Show* brownstone). Drawing from ROJEK (1997), TORCHIN (2002, 251) applies the concept of "dragging" to the tour: signs, symbols, and images in movies and TV "are dragged onto the physical landscape and the physical landscape is then reinterpreted in terms of [these] cinematic events." In other words, place unfolds as an amalgam, simultaneously real and mediated. Place emerges, not only by our presence in it, but with fragments and figments of our *musée imaginaire* and the thrill of association with the more exciting, simulated world of TV. Through all of these, reality is enhanced, and "the everyday world of New York City is reconfigured as interesting" (TORCHIN 2002, 248).

More recently, media geographies have turned to a radically different understanding of the ontology of film and television. CRESSWELL and DIXON (2002, 3–4) argue that visual media is not simply "mere images of unmediated expressions of the mind, but rather the temporary embodiment of social processes that continually construct and deconstruct the world as we know it." They go on to argue that the dominance of the textual metaphor in media geography reinforces the reel/real binary through its focus on text and context, implying a fixed positionality of the observer as she relates to a film or television show. The reel/real restricts inquiry of the spatiality of media. LUKINBEAL and ZIMMERMANN (2006, 322) challenge this normative belief in stating:

We eschew the representational determinism that film geography is synonymous with *re-*presentations of some ontological stable "authentic" reality. Drawing from CRANG et al. (1999, 2), we posit that film geography always exceeds the cinematic technologies which produce representations because film is "constituted by the social relations, discourses and sites in which these technologies are embedded." The technologies that capture, encode and represent the world are always embedded in social and cultural practices that are temporally and spatially specific. Representations are not the polar opposite of reality especially when it comes to film and cinema. Cinematic images are always socialized just as technologies are always socialized.

The textual metaphor is a hermeneutical method that assumes that cinema and television are authored and can be read like texts. While humanistic inquiries into the textual metaphor (cf. LEWIS 1979; MEINIG 1979) focused on "natural" or an "automatic" reading of the landscape, new cultural geographers have problematized the meanings associated with "reading," "writing" and "text" (DUNCAN and DUNCAN 1988; DUNCAN 1990; BARNES and DUNCAN 1992; COSGROVE 1993; DUNCAN and LEY 1993). The textual metaphor presupposes that there is no single "author," for it is through the act of "reading" that production and reproduction occurs. While landscapes, films, and television shows are written and read by experts and ordinary people alike, they constitute and reflect power relations that exist in culture and society (DUNCAN and DUNCAN 1988). The textual metaphor does not offer a meta-narrative which can read landscapes, but rather suggests an intertextual world of cultural signifying practices whereby a text is understood, interpreted and constituted by relations with other cultural texts. Landscape, film, and television are intertextually related to other systems of cultural production and reproduction (cf. COSGROVE 1984, 1987, 1993; DANIELS and COSGROVE 1988; DANIELS 1989).

When applied to film analysis, the textual metaphor often has the effect of limiting spatial inquiry to internal textual properties. According to HAY (1997, 214), cultural criticism through textual analysis focuses on the "internal properties of texts or upon the relations among film texts" which suggests a "kind of placelessness of an absolutely separate place of the literary/filmic in social relations and history." Textual analysis, according to HAY (1997, 214), assumes that the reading of the text is done from "no place in particular" and that critical theory applied to a text is done from "anywhere." From this vantage point, the textual metaphor assumes a "counter-public sphere" from which we might "intervene in social relations without addressing the locational politics of such a sphere" (HAY 1997, 214). While HAY does not take into account that geographers have addressed the cultural politics of authorship (DUNCAN and LEY 1993; ROSE 1993), his argument does point to a gap in our understanding of the spatial politics of the textual metaphor.

By reducing film and television to text, it becomes an instrument and gives research the status of a reading. This not only fetishizes space by making the researcher's mental space envelop social and physical space (LEFEBVRE 1991), but it also sidesteps the history and social practices associated with the film production industry. The textual metaphor is a powerful and appropriate means of engaging spatial politics of the gaze and optical power inherent in film and television. But, we must realize that the textual metaphor has limits; there are extra-textual cultural processes that cannot be captured adequately via this metaphor, most notably the optical unconscious. The textual metaphor never truly offers what SMITH and KATZ (1993) call an *effective* and *coherent* spatialized politics because, according to HAY (1997), the locational politics of what is cinematic or televisual remains fixated on the narrative space within the text. Just as spatial metaphors work to hide cultural processes related to historical materialism (SMITH and KATZ 1993), the textual metaphor applied to film and television overlooks intertextual and extra-textual processes. It is our contention that cinema and television always exceed the space defined by the textual metaphor. To focus primarily on text in analyzing visual media runs the risk of losing touch with how television and cinema affect and engage everyday life.

TELEVISUAL PLACE AS SIMULACRAL

In his 1935 essay "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction," Walter BENJAMIN addresses the profound effects of film on art and society, astutely recognizing early on that film would reconfigure traditional modes of representation. If art is a representation of reality, film creates a much different representation than a stage play or a painting: The movie camera penetrates reality so completely that it presents "an aspect of reality which is free of all equipment," says BENJAMIN (1968, 234), "and that is what one is entitled to ask from a work of art." Furthermore, as articulated by CLARKE (1997, 9), the audience sees from the camera's point of view such that film is not merely a "*representation* of space"

but “(re)produces a virtual space” and, in effect, achieves a “re-framing of the world” (emphasis in original). The technology of film allowed us to see the world in novel ways, such as in close-up and in slow motion. “Cinema is at once a form of perception and a material perceived, a new way of encountering reality and a part of reality thereby perceived for the first time” (SHAVIRO 1993, cited in CLARKE 1997, 2). Indeed, from the comfort of home or as one in the crowd at a movie theatre, BENJAMIN (1968, 236) was prescient in arguing that film would change our experience of the world:

● Our taverns and our metropolitan streets, our offices and furnished rooms, our railroad stations and our factories appeared to have us locked up hopelessly. Then came the film and burst this prison-world asunder ... so that now, in the midst of its far-flung ruins and debris, we calmly and adventurously go traveling.

The subsequent development of montage furthered the manipulation of space and time, so that film was freed from its role as a “referential medium, bound to the Real, to become a *simulacral* medium, free to fabricate a reality-effect” (DOEL 2008, 96). Montage now presents a “reality effect” such that “once assembled, a film does not re-present a world that preexisted it” (DOEL and CLARKE 2007, 897). Film and television create their own realities that provide an experience in and of themselves (AITKEN and ZONN 1994; CLARKE 1997; DOEL and CLARKE 2007).

BAUDRILLARD’s postmodern theory jettisoned the belief that there is “an existing, knowable world,” a truth to be revealed behind the media’s glossy images (BEST and KELLNER 1997, 101). As a radical reconfiguration of Marxist theory, BAUDRILLARD saw that beyond both use value and exchange value, the commodity is purchased for its sign value, not for what it is, but for what it represents. Clothes and cars, rather than body coverings and transportation, have become success and glamour. What we see on television is what we strive to be, and our actions are conditioned by the movies. BAUDRILLARD claims that media images have so thoroughly permeated experience that we have lost any referent to the real; the image is reality (BEST and KELLNER 1997).

In webs of virtuality, we are left with nothing more and nothing less than a system of simulacra: “realer-than-real” constructions, depthless artifices, copies without an original, a “hyperreality.” For BAUDRILLARD, the mass media have disturbed the ontology of the entire social world (BEST and KELLNER 1997). Unlike Adorno, BAUDRILLARD does not view the masses as defeated or duped, but as bored, over-stimulated, and unquestioning, and it is by ignoring the media’s message that we, in effect, resist it. Caught as we are in worlds of simulacra, we are plunged “into a state of stupor”: “a radical uncertainty as to our own desire, our own choice, our own opinion, our own will” (BAUDRILLARD 1988a, 209). We suffer from “a state of suspense and of definitive uncertainty about reality” (BAUDRILLARD 1988a, 210). All we can do is “absorb it without reply”; this is our silent act of defiance (POSTER 1988).

Worlds created by film press into everyday life. BAUDRILLARD (1988b, 55–56) explains:

In fact, the cinema here is not where you think it is. It is certainly not to be found in the studios the tourist crowds flock to ... Where is the cinema? It is all around you outside, all over the city, that marvelous, continuous performance of films and scenarios ... The American city seems to have stepped right out of the movies ... [cinema] invests the streets and the entire town with a mythical atmosphere.

In BAUDRILLARD's (1988b, 104) words, "The cinema and TV are America's reality!" In light of this revelation, LUKINBEAL and ZIMMERMANN (2006, 11) raise the question: "What if the copy is better than the original? What if the original never existed but is a myth?" In his examination of LA's Hollywood redevelopment project, STENGER (2001) demonstrates that there can be serious material repercussions when the simulated world of film is better-than-real. "Hollywood-the-place" is being made over so as not to disappoint tourists expecting to see "Hollywood-the-cultural-myth" (STENGER 2001, 71). The redevelopment of Hollywood Boulevard is well on its way to becoming a simulacrum of a simulacrum. Television and cinema are simulacral, which shifts the mode of inquiry away from the problematic reel/real binary to the openness afforded by mediated place. We are not passive viewers or voyeurs of movement-images; we are active itinerates participating in, and creating, meaningful experiences and connections vis-à-vis place.

PREVIEW OF COMING ATTRACTIONS

Our exploration of Orange County and the ways in which television and the media are intimately involved in place-making begins in chapter two. In this chapter, we trace the mediated and geographical imaginary of Orange County prior to its television popularity. This is followed in chapter three by an examination of the popular culture transformation of the County of Orange into the "OC" as a result of the shows *The OC*, *Laguna Beach: The Real Orange County*, and *The Real Housewives of Orange County*. These chapters provide background needed to position Orange County as a mediated place, highlighting ongoing processes of identity formation in mediated place-making.

In chapter four we address landscape and place-making, accentuating production techniques in television relating to geographic realism. In chapter five we reveal how emotional realism works to produce an affective response in televisual place-making. Chapter six draws on survey data to explore ways in which audiences experience "reality" TV shows. Here we highlight the tension between television as a re-presentation of Orange County itself and as an affective agent engendering emotional attachment to something called the "OC." Chapter seven delves into the tension between the optical reel/real place and the anti-optical emotional affect via a touristic experience by the lead author (Ann) in search of "the OC." We conclude in chapter eight with a discussion of the paradox of two places in one location: the County of Orange and the "OC" as mutually inclusive and exclusive.

CHAPTER 4

LANDSCAPE AND PLACE-MAKING ON TELEVISION

How do the television shows *The OC*, *Laguna Beach: The Real Orange County*, and *The Real Housewives of Orange County* use production techniques to assemble the place called “the OC”? In this chapter we argue that the work of place-making occurs through construction of a montage of the four functions landscape serves in television and cinema (place, space, spectacle, and metaphor).

One of the most intriguing tensions in landscape studies is how it is constituted. For some it is “a portion of the earth’s surface which can be comprehended at a glance” (JACKSON 1984, 8), or “our unwitting autobiography, reflecting our tastes, our values, our aspirations, and even our fears, in tangible, visible form” (LEWIS 1979, 12). From these perspectives, landscape is a fixed, solid entity, “a text already written” (CRESSWELL 2003, 27), but a text that is nonetheless structured by vision. These characterizations of landscape rely on the belief that it is a cultural product (ROBERTSON and RICHARDS 2003), or a particular “way of seeing” (COSGROVE 1984, 1). But as MITCHELL (2008, 44) notes, as

a particular, structured way of seeing, landscape has historically been established as *the* way of seeing. Landscape is didactic in that it teaches us to look in certain ways and to value aesthetics (over any number of other ways of knowing) as a means toward understanding the nature, status, and meaning of a place.

Thus, the dominant way of seeing our “unwitting autobiography” (LEWIS 1979, 12) reflects the status quo, but is always in competition “for organizational power within any culture” (FLECKENSTEIN 2006, 70).

As a cultural product, landscape is always-already a representation. Whether seen on the television screen or as a material manifestation, landscape is a “potent cultural symbol” to be consumed by viewers (MITCHELL 1994, 15). If place is a way of understanding the world (CRESSWELL 2004) and a center of felt value (TUAN 1977), then landscape, as cultural product, contributes to place-making by naturalizing meaning, values, and power relations. According to DUNCAN and LEY (1993), naturalizing refers to the ways in which landscape and representations seek to pass off that which is cultural (meaning, values, and power relations) as natural. Those with the power to define the view imbue the landscape with cultural meaning to invoke a particular message about place, one that resonates with viewers. However, while landscapes (and television shows) are sites of cultural production and reproduction, “not all audiences will be able or willing to

respond to the way of seeing invited by a particular image and its particular practices of display" (ROSE 2001, 15).

Understanding landscape as a cultural product risks overlooking its dynamism. Landscape is also a cultural process, "an ongoing *relationship* between people and place" (MITCHELL 2000, 102). As we go about our daily lives, we do so within the landscape, continually shaping and re-creating it. In this sense, what matters is "not what the landscape means but, rather, how it comes to be meaningful" (ROSE 2002, 456) and relevant for our own lives. As MCHUGH (2009, 209) notes, "Landscape is emergent as relational lines of movement, an ongoing meshwork of practices and movement signatures." The process of "living" the landscape is the same process inherent in place-making. As landscape becomes meaningful through practice and engagement with it, the place that landscape embodies becomes present – is created. According to MCHUGH (2009, 209), "we are nothing more and nothing less than agents, next selves, 'passing' through. The collective traces of our 'passings' constitutes the making and remaking of place." In the words of CASEY (2002, 271), "Landscapes are, in the final analysis, placescapes; they are congeries of place in the fullest experiential and represented sense." As congeries of place, landscape is co-constituted by the actual (present) and the virtual (past) where memory is vital, "pushing forward in duration, the dynamic continuation of movement and sensation" (MCHUGH 2009, 209). According to BRUNO (2007, 39),

in this vein, a cultural landscape, broadly conceived, can be regarded in many ways as a trace of the memories, the attention, and the imagination of that inhabitant – passengers who have traversed it at different times. It is an intertextual terrain of passage carrying its own presentation in the threads of its fabric, weaving it on intersecting screens. A palpable imprint is left in this moving landscape: in its folds, gaps, and layers, the geography of cinema ... holds remnants of what has projected onto it at every *transito*, including *emotions*. Imaged in this way, such a landscape is an archaeology of the present.

THE FUNCTIONS OF LANDSCAPE

Landscape, as both cultural process and product, works to create place. Drawing from HIGSON (1984, 1987), LUKINBEAL (2005) asserts that landscape serves four functions in cinema and television: as space, place, spectacle, and metaphor. As space, landscape is a site of dialogue or action, where the drama of the narrative comes to the foreground (AITKEN and ZONN 1994; LUKINBEAL 2005). Landscape as place promotes geographic realism, imbuing television with a specific sense of place. Geographic realism is an aesthetic practice that links a fictional narrative to a sense of place, regardless of whether or not the actual filmed location has any relation to the fictional narrative (LUKINBEAL 2006). Once geographic realism is established, viewers are more apt to suspend their disbelief and accept the meanings appropriated onto the landscape (LUKINBEAL 2005, 2006). HIGSON (1984, 3) explains:

Landscape and townscape shots must at one level construct a narrative space in which the protagonists of the drama can perform the various actions of the plot. But more than a neutral space, these location shots demand to be read as a real historical *place*, authenticating the fiction.

HIGSON (1984, 9) continues: "place becomes a 'sign of reality': the implication is that it speaks a history, a memory." Memory, movement, and emotion are experienced as a *musée imaginaire* (MALRAUX 1967), a metacinema (MCHUGH 2009), an "emotional map ... we experience, on topophilic grounds, an architecture of inner voyage, a geography of intimate space. Filmic site-seeing is immersed in the geopsychic act of interfacing affect and place ..." (BRUNO 2007, 39).

Landscape as place (cultural product) is achieved most efficiently through the repetitive use of landscape images in establishing shots. These create a cognitive map in viewers' minds, setting the scene within which narrative space can unfold (LUKINBEAL 2005). Oddly enough, while establishing shots are "tools for spatial orientation," they are almost always montage sequences, a fragmented collection of images (BANERJEE and MARX 2008, 156). According to BANERJEE and MARX (2008, 156), establishing shots fulfill a paradoxical task:

While functioning as indices of reality for the fictional construction, at the same time they increasingly become elements of a specific cultural code that marks the genre, and to a certain degree, the specific television series.

Repetitive use of images in establishing shots build a representational legacy, a lexicon of icons that "operate as a sort of short hand; they must carry with them a whole baggage of cultural meanings that can be instantly unpacked by the viewer who recognizes the baggage" (HIGSON 1987, 11). Especially in television, operating under the constraints of a timeslot frequently interrupted by commercial breaks, place must be expressed in an efficient manner. SADLER and HASKINS (2005, 201) explain the effect:

In New York City, the repeated use of the skyline image has reinforced the city's place and has clarified the image in people's minds to the point that most people can recognize the Big Apple from a small piece of the overall image.

Landscape often functions simultaneously as place and spectacle. As spectacle, landscape is presented as "a visually pleasurable lure to the spectator's eye" (HIGSON 1984, 3), an image to be consumed by the viewer, who holds a "position of visual mastery" (HIGSON 1984, 19). Spectacular landscapes suspend narrative space, allowing the spectacle to come to the foreground (AITKEN and ZONN 1994). This suspension of narrative space creates a provocative tension between the desire to linger on the view and the forward movement of the narrative, or the drive to find out what happens next (HIGSON 1984). Narrative instills a "sense of something lacking ... a desire to explore," while a spectacular landscape confronts viewers with "an image which is so fascinating that it seems complete; no longer the desire to move on, no longer the sense of something lacking ..." (HIGSON 1984, 3). Spectacle, therefore, works on two levels: it constructs emotional maps (BRUNO 2007) that combines (e)motion with memory and intimate space, and it

encodes power relations within the gaze, such as the hegemony of the masculine gaze in landscape studies (ROSE 1993) and cinema (MULVEY 1975).

Through the use of metaphor, landscape is infused with cultural or social meaning which links icons and stereotypes to place and spaces (LUKINBEAL 2005). These stereotypes become naturalized ways of seeing, and like icons, they are constructed and reinforced through repetition. For example, in cinema, the city is often presented in opposition to the country to represent loss of innocence (MCARTHUR 1997). Metaphorical landscape can visually express a character's state of mind, as rain often signifies sadness: "it is not just that the character is in the landscape, but that the landscape becomes part of the character" (HIGSON 1984, 12). Landscapes of metaphor and spectacle can both generate pauses in narrative, producing "meeting places" where memory, emotion, actions, and events craft a representational legacy – a place imbued with meaning to viewers of the show. Metaphor, like spectacle, can also ease the tensions between place and space by allowing the social meaning(s) of place to be appropriated to space and vice versa.

Finally, space is central to the construction of social meaning. HIGSON (1987, 8) describes landscape's primary function on television as a "discourse space: that is, as the space in which people talk ... as figures in the landscape." These spaces are integral to the ongoing process of place-making. Within such spaces important dialogue is uttered by characters, revealing facial expressions are captured in close-up, and movements are tracked, all presented within a television show to build characters' personalities and expand viewers' understanding of their lives and situation. Here landscape is primarily a process; a narrative space of actions and dialogue assumes prominence in these scenes; they further the social meaning of place, deepening our understanding of this televisual world.

As HEATH (1981, 31) notes, in cinema the *mise-en-scène* is constructed as a narrative space, a *quattrocento* system in that is a "cued construction of space." Rather than a static and temporarily fixed space (like a painting), mobility in and of the image disrupts the pictorial organization of the composition (cf. DOEL and CLARKE 2007). Movement literally animates (or gives life) that forces narrative space to contain "the mobility that could threaten the clarity of vision in a constant renewal of perspective; space becomes place – narrative as the taking place in film ..." (HEATH 1981, 36). HEATH (1981, 37) goes on to argue that "what is crucial is the conversion of seen into scene, the holding of signifier on signified; the frame composed, centered, narrated, is the point of that conversion." Mobility thus poses a problem to the construction of narrative space. It de-centers a coherent place by using it up, requiring spatial cues (such as establishing shots, transition shots, editing, and montage) to return clarity to the narrative. By first directing the viewer's attention to the geographic realism of establishing shots, then to involvement in actions and reactions of the characters within discourse space, and later returning to an establishing shot, there is a constant tension between space and place, or between landscape as cultural process and product, within the narrative.

In the end, it is difficult to separate the functions of landscape as they are techniques used in television and film to create place through ongoing tensions and transitions between space and place, a progression driven by TV's production codes and generic formulas. Landscape as place continually falls away to narrative space and back again (cf. AITKEN and ZONN 1994), and landscape as metaphor and spectacle links, overlaps, and releases the tension between place and space. The process of televisual place-making requires constant tension and continuous scalar movements between landscape, place, and space. Where space constructs a localized sense of social place and allows televisual place to become meaningful through the unfolding of narrative events, place grounds the narrative, provides geographic realism, and establishes broad cultural meanings.

AN ICONOGRAPHY OF ORANGE COUNTY

The televisual functions of landscape are well-illustrated in the pilot episode of *The OC*. The pilot is an important episode; its task is to construct the spaces that characters inhabit and build the foundations of place essential to a successful series. Especially for a show aiming to hook viewers on an extravagant lifestyle, the first impression must be captivating. Orange County is masterfully introduced in the first 15 minutes of *The OC*'s pilot episode.

The show opens in dark, dangerous Chino where our hero, Ryan, is shown as a hesitant accomplice to car theft (Figure 37). Ryan gets caught, spends time in juvie, and is thrown out of his mother's house. With nowhere else to turn, he calls Sandy Cohen, his public defender, and Sandy drives him out of gritty, graffiti-ridden Chino and into beautiful Newport Beach. The camera tracks their car as it drives down the coast, past surfers, sunbathers, and kids playing touch football on the beach, in the striking hues of an ocean sunset. The montage ends as the car enters the Cohens' gated community and pulls into their impressive abode (Figure 38). Through Ryan's eyes, and ours (the camera's), there is quite a contrast between life in the run-down landscape of Chino, and the other-worldliness of a sunny, wealthy, seemingly flawless Orange County. Here landscape functions as a metaphor of contrast: Chino serves as the stereotypical ghetto and Newport the beachfront Babylon. Place-making proceeds as much by using landscape to symbolize what the OC is not (or should never be confused with). By painting place in black and white, in definable disparity, the contrast between these landscapes posits Orange County as paradise, the dream world to which Ryan and the viewers are introduced.

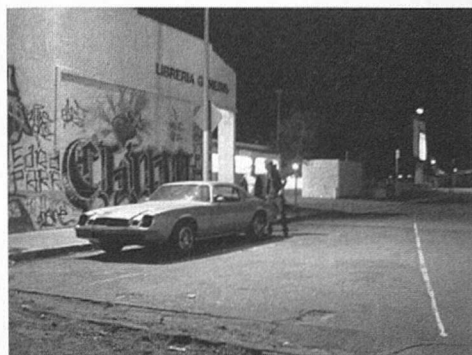


Figure 37. Opening scene of *The OC*, in Chino

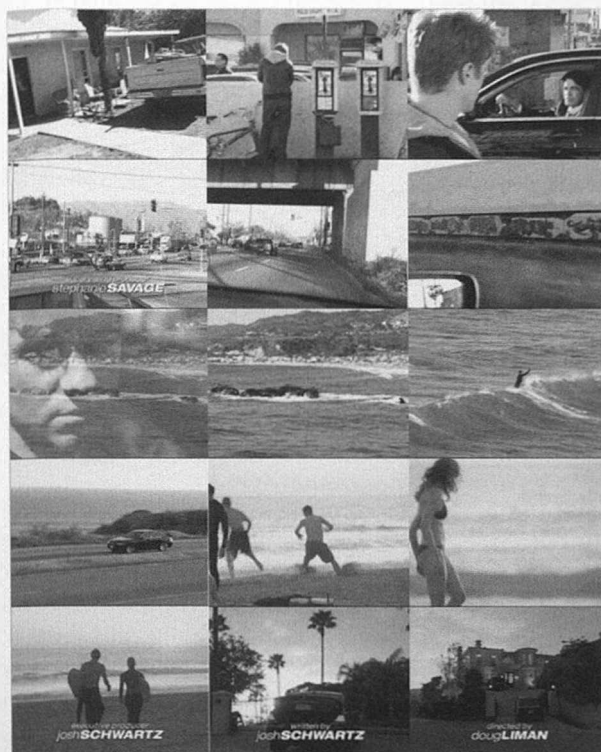


Figure 38. Ryan's journey from Chino to "the OC"

Following the pilot, each subsequent episode begins with a traditional opening sequence, which introduces the cast and, of course, "the OC." Establishing shots contained in this montage reaffirm the central elements of televisual Orange County by showcasing landscape as spectacle: first a shot of Newport Coast mansions, then waves breaking on the coast, a sailboat on the ocean, a jet skier, the pier, a beautiful bikini-clad girl, a sunset, and finally Ryan's pool house, rapidly shifting from icon to icon, none lingering on the screen quite long enough



Figure 40. Transitional shot of character's home



Figure 41. Transitional shot of Balboa Pier in Newport Beach

The repetitive use of transitional shots during an episode and throughout the series reinforces and reminds viewers of the naturalized meanings inherent in geographic realism. The harbor vistas to which *The OC* so frequently returns prompt viewers to associate Orange County with wealth and warm weather. These landscapes are used as evidence that the fictional narrative is occurring in the actual location. But as LUKINBEAL (2006, 339) argues, geographic realism “is subjective and fluid, not objective and factual.” PECKMAN (2004) also notes that realism is not about mimesis; it is an effect codified by conventions. Ironically, with the exception of some of its establishing and transitional shots, *The OC* is filmed not in Orange County, but rather in Los Angeles. This “crime against geography” (LUKINBEAL and ZIMMERMANN 2006, 8) was committed as a result of the economics associated with the “The Zone,” a thirty-mile radius centered on Beverly and La Cienega Boulevards in Los Angeles, outside of which labor union rules make it prohibitively expensive to film (LUKINBEAL 2004). In the final analysis, it does not matter whether a show was filmed in OC or LA; economic concerns dictate that as long as landscape signifies a real place that can pass as the original, realism has been achieved (LUKINBEAL 2006).

LAGUNA BEACH

Like *The OC*, *Laguna Beach* also depends heavily upon images of the physical landscape to construct place, yet it provides even more spectacular landscapes than those of *The OC*, laying claim to the title of “best-looking show on television” (HEFFERNAN 2005). *Laguna Beach*, different than your run-of-the-mill reality show, has a much higher production value. The show was shot in cinematic style using a widescreen aspect ratio, elaborate lighting configurations, and several special digital cameras, often at sunset, to effectively emphasize the natural beauty of the city and its residents (DEMPSEY 2004; HEFFERNAN 2005).

Establishing shots produce the stunning Laguna Beach setting. In a manner similar to the opening credits of *The OC*, we see, in rapid montage, waves breaking on the beach, Laguna’s picturesque coastline, palm trees, a mansion, a tide pool, and several sunsets over water (Figure 42). Again, the camera’s gaze does not linger long on these spectacular images; rather our attention is drawn through the credits to the start of the episode. The montage sequence packages landscape as spectacle, which attracts our attention and constructs the place that is televisual Laguna Beach.



Figure 42. Laguna Beach opening sequence

The opening sequence, furthermore, is set to teen pop star Hilary Duff's "Come Clean," a song whose lyrics begin with the word "perfect," and continue with the phrase "Let the rain fall down; And wake my dreams; Let it wash away; My sanity," fitting words to accompany such stunning vistas. Paired with this musical cue, metaphor and spectacle merge to produce a "perfect" lifestyle in a "perfect" place, evoking the carefree years of high school, or as expressed by BELLAFANTE (2007), the high school experience we dream we might have had.

Each episode commences with a "Previously on *Laguna Beach*" screen, in which this text is transposed onto a landscape image used repetitively in the series – a landscape that has now become a *Laguna Beach* icon (Figure 43). Following this establishing shot and the opening credits, the episode title is reinscribed within a similar repetitive, iconic, spectacular backdrop (Figure 44). Also, shots of cast members' homes and restaurants and shops they frequent become familiar landmarks, reinforcing a *Laguna* sense of place while assisting viewers' navigation of this mediascape (Figure 45).

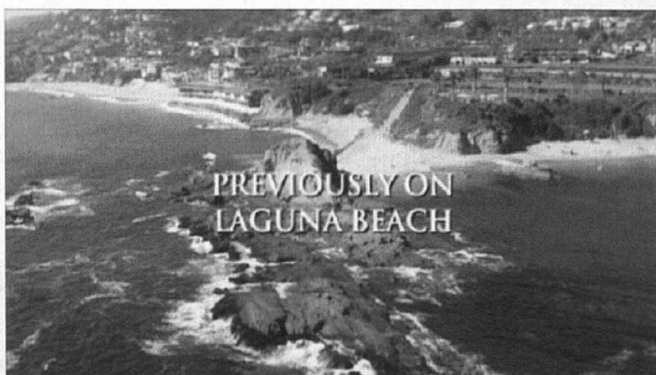


Figure 43. The iconic Laguna Beach landscape



Figure 44. Episode title screen

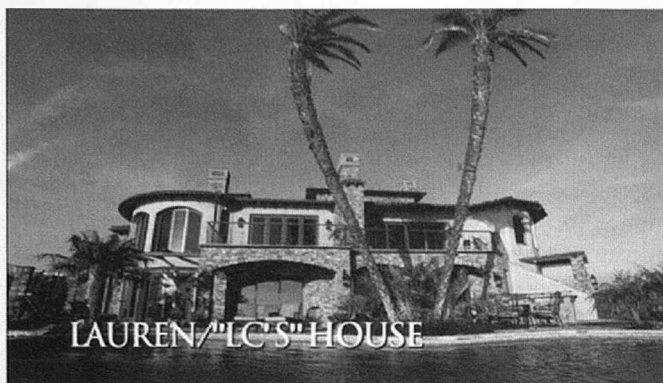


Figure 45. Transitional shot of cast member's home

Establishing shots, opening sequences, and transitional shots in *Laguna Beach* are emotionally charged and affect our voyeuristic desires, anticipating viewers' interpretation of narrative significance. It is the transitional shots, however, that most effectively establish place in *Laguna Beach*. These shots are often aerial views of Laguna's townscape, Laguna as seen from the ocean, closer views of downtown, or other city icons (Figure 46). Several such landscapes (always different) are presented between scenes throughout the course of each twenty-minute episode to musical accompaniment. Music and landscape move together across scenes, creating affective and emotional currents in animating place and place meanings.



Figure 46. Laguna Beach transitional shots

THE REAL HOUSEWIVES

The Real Housewives, a lower-budget cable reality program, also uses spectacle to introduce viewers to life in an Orange County gated community. Rather than the breathtaking beaches and seascapes of *The OC* and *Laguna Beach*, *Real Housewives* features images of inland wealth: expansive homes, expensive cars, emerald golf courses, picturesque palms, bejeweled women, wine, Jacuzzis and swimming pools, horseback riding at sunset. Voice-over narration informs:

Life is different in a gated community. Land here is one million an acre, the average-priced house is one million eight to two-two. Once people come through this gate, there's a sense of being Teflon-ed – nothing sticks to you. Image is everything in my world. When you're not behind the gates, you don't know what you're missing. This isn't just a place to live, it's a lifestyle.

The penultimate image of this sequence shows Coto de Caza from a distance, miles of homes perched atop a hill, buttressed with the caption “7 million families live in gated communities.” The final title screen is a somewhat sinister image of gates closing over uncharacteristically dark skies (Figure 47). As discussed above, a pilot episode is burdened with the task of introducing this setting and convincing viewers that residents of Orange County lead compelling lives. These landscapes, especially the symbolism of the gates, position the ladies of Coto in a place which is highly differentiated, socio-economically, from its surroundings. Meanings associated with the gates and other signifiers of social status establish Orange County as a very exclusive entity. The ominous image of closing gates also conveys a sense that although it may look like paradise, life inside has a darker, dramatic quality.



Figure 47. Introduction to Coto de Caza

In each episode, *The Real Housewives* regularly utilizes landscape to familiarize viewers with the ladies' environment, to construct televisual place. In the opening

sequence, we are formally introduced to the ladies and see them engaged in a variety of “Orange County” activities, including stepping into a hot tub with a glass of wine, receiving Botox treatments, drinking a martini on horseback, and trying on diamond necklaces (Figure 48). Transitional shots warn viewers that we will be updated on the goings-on of a different cast member and generally consist of cast members’ homes and various bars/restaurants where cast members socialize (Figure 49). Later seasons more regularly use spectacular transitional shots of the Coto landscape – its golf courses, fancy cars, and even Newport Harbor – to re-establish the opulence of the setting and to recapture the viewers’ attention. Again, these landscapes ensure that, as viewers are transported across and between the social spaces which comprise televisual Orange County, place-based meaning follows.



Figure 48. *The Real Housewives opening sequence*



Figure 49. *Transitional shot of cast member's home*

Although the housewives operate in a somewhat different social milieu than the teenage stars of *Laguna Beach* and *The OC* (the grownup version), together, these

shows construct a singular televisual Orange County; landscape creates a similar place in all three. Spectacular and metaphorical landscapes presented in establishing and transitional shots all position Orange County as a place of wealth, privilege, and great physical beauty. Images of the beach, warm weather leisure activities, and characters' beautiful homes are presented in each show to orient the audience and to reinforce the cultural meanings contained in this televisual place.

Thus far we have elaborated on landscape's role as cultural product in place-making. Through establishing and transitional shots, landscape serves as an object to be gazed upon, a frame from which to experience the TV world, a conveyor of cultural meaning and geographic realism. These landscapes express broad, rather generic meanings about televisual place. We now turn to landscape as cultural process, to the spaces which produce a more intimate and emotional engagement with televisual place.

LANDSCAPE AS SPACE

Landscape, even when presented and read as a cultural product, is always a work in progress. Landscape is continually shaped, transformed, and discovered as we make our way through it. Through our interactions with landscape, place emerges and comes into being (ROSE 2002). When the function of landscape shifts from place to space, discursive space also shifts from mere background to occupy the foreground of the *mise-en-scène*. This is a scalar shift; one that moves from wide angle, long range, deep focus, or aerial shots to close ups and spaces of dialogue, events, and actions. Here place is turned into a social space which allows the narrative to unfold, an essential function in televisual place-making.

In *The OC*, discourse space often takes the form of the Cohen home or the pool house where Ryan resides. In the pilot alone, the viewer accompanies Ryan and Seth on a sailboat, to a swanky fashion show fundraiser, and to a party at a beach house. Subsequent episodes feature scenes at a debutante ball, a casino night fundraiser, several lavish parties, and other spaces intended to promote an extravagant lifestyle. Other frequently used settings are the characters' private high school, the real estate development offices where Kirsten works, a diner on the pier, and the beach. These settings undoubtedly work to promote the idea of an extravagant Orange County lifestyle, but it is within social space that these scenes *take place*. It is at the high school and at the parties where viewers get to know the characters, are appraised of their dramatic situations, see the emotion in their faces, and hear the words they speak to each other. It is within these social spaces that Orange County becomes meaningful to its audience, and thus becomes a place.

Because *The OC* is a fictional dramatic series, complex storylines take characters on a variety of adventures in new places which are featured in one or more episodes until the storyline is played to a close. For example, in episode fifteen of season two, the main characters get locked in a mall overnight; the mall is not a regular social space in the series and is only used once as a plot device.

These transient places are not an integral component of the characters' world, but nonetheless expand the mediated Orange County landscape. These places offer new opportunities for social space to unfold; they are literally "meeting places" (cf. MASSEY 1994, 154).

Barred from filming in the local high school, and largely devoid of authority figures, the social spaces of *Laguna Beach* present a very specific slice of teenage life in the "real" Orange County. Through producers' choice of filming locations, Orange County becomes a charmed place where moneyed, photogenic teens can party and surf with worries of neither parents nor school. Approximately forty percent of the show's scenes (from fifteen episodes sampled) are filmed in cast members' homes: a few friends chat while lounging on the deck or laying out by the pool. The home also frequently serves as a party venue, and parents and siblings rarely appear in these scenes.

Approximately twenty percent of the series' social spaces are cafes or nice restaurants (most of the restaurant scenes document ersatz dates). Another twenty percent of scenes are shot at the beach, which proves an appropriate gathering place for gossiping, showing off surfing skills, as well as for breaking up with boyfriends or girlfriends. Viewers also frequently accompany cast members to local boutiques and the nail salon (Figure 50). Occasionally we glimpse these teens at their workplaces, but these are boutiques and surf shops, not burger joints, and therefore function as a convenient place for friends to stop by to chat about upcoming social events. Many other once- or twice-used locations depart from the home-beach-restaurant trifecta, but nevertheless succeed in furthering the show's presentation of a specific Laguna Beach lifestyle. These include a journey to Catalina Island by yacht, a resort in Cabo San Lucas (Mexico), senior prom, a BMW dealership, and the occasional fashion show benefit (note that *The OC* first used this device to depict an Orange County lifestyle in its pilot).



Figure 50. At the nail salon, a favorite Laguna Beach pastime

Again, these discursive spaces are not devoid of meaning. Instead, they provide the sites central to place-making. On the deck or at the beach, characters' lives are revealed and these places are made meaningful. Cafes, boutiques, restaurants, and the beach comprise a well-defined mediascape, and participants therein turn these locations into place through practice.

Furthermore, *Laguna Beach* takes advantage of the area's significant physical beauty in a unique way, by combining medium shots of the landscape with narrative action, in what could be termed "Laguna clichés:" characters are often captured having cell phone conversations on their decks at dusk, heartfelt talks at the beach or beach overlooks, or at seaside bonfires in the evenings (Figure 51). While social space is created through characters' emotional revelations within these landscapes, landscape also functions as metaphor and spectacle to enhance the narrative. A gaze off into the ocean, for example, after breaking up with a boyfriend or just prior to leaving Laguna's bubble for college suggests a regretful or reflective state of mind (Figure 52). Here, as elsewhere, metaphor and spectacle serves as an intermediary between place and space, animating the place-making process.

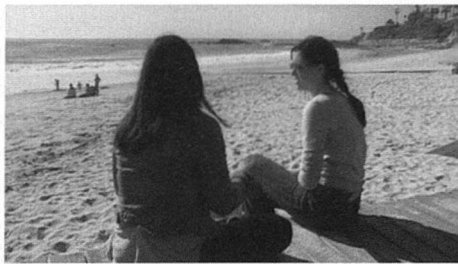


Figure 51. *Laguna cliché*



Figure 52. *Landscape as metaphor and spectacle*

By interweaving spectacular, transitional landscapes with this impressive roster of social spaces, *Laguna Beach* constructs Laguna Beach as a parent-less, homework-free world of surfing, swimming, shopping, and partying. Unfettered by the burdens of educational responsibility, landscape produces a place of consumption-based leisure, a lifestyle broadcasted to fans throughout the country and the world.

Similar to *Laguna Beach*, place-making on *Housewives* most often occurs in cast members' homes and in nice restaurants. Because landscape as spectacle or metaphor is less often used in this series, filming locations play a heightened role in crafting mediated Orange County, using up place to create a space within which narrative action will unfold.

The home is a significant component of the housewives' social landscape. As it is much easier to gain permission to film inside a private residence than a public area, roughly fifty percent of each show (from fifteen episodes sampled) takes place in cast members' homes, where the women interact with their families and throw a number of backyard barbeques. Familial relations play a key role in the creation of the homescape, as children and husbands deepen our knowledge of the women's social space and provide drama and conflict. Just as the *Laguna Beach* landscape is all but devoid of parental authority, husbands and other men have a limited presence on *The Real Housewives*; included, it seems, when needed for dramatic purposes. Children are usually featured as spoiled and demanding. These family dynamics produce a social space centered on youth and women.

Nearly thirty percent of filming locations outside the home are bars and restaurants where the women *always* order drinks (Figure 53). Approximately ten percent are trips to salons and spas, and shopping accounts for another ten percent of outside activities. There are also trips to the beach, the Coto de Caza Golf and Racquet Club, and horse stables. Other notable gathering places include an after-work visit to "Vicki's Backyard Spa," hula lessons with Kimberly and her teenage daughter, dinner and a night spent at the swanky St. Regis Resort, a "Botox party" in the office of a Newport Beach plastic surgeon, and a trip back to Illinois for Vicki's twenty-fifth high school reunion. Also, several of the women take trips to Mexico, one goes to Palm Springs for a "weekend with the girls," a family trip is taken to Lake Havasu, and all of the ladies spend a weekend together at a posh hotel in San Diego (which they reach by limo). For the most part, the ladies engage in expensive, enjoyable activities which reinforce a selective Orange County social landscape and maintain the spectacle of a luxurious landscape.

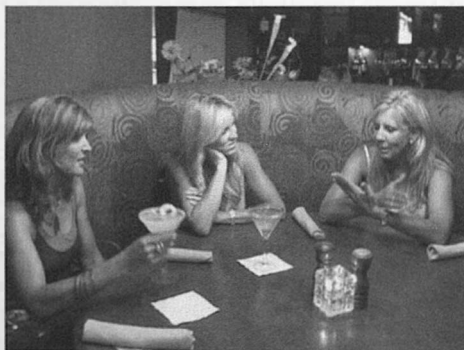


Figure 53. Drinking at a bar/restaurant

The Real Housewives shows life in an Orange County gated community as a montage of eating out and otherwise socializing; rarely does this lifestyle entail an eight-plus-hour workday and grocery shopping. Although we occasionally glimpse realtor Jeana showing a (very expensive) house or see type-A Vicki bustling in her office, the workaday aspects of this "real" life are disproportionately reduced to enhance social places critical to constructing a particular

leisure-based OC lifestyle. As does Vicki to maintain her extravagant lifestyle, landscape as social space works hard in this series to create a specific type of place. These spaces draw viewers deeper into the milieu of a Coto resident. At these restaurants, we are privy to the ladies' complaints of their husbands, their kids, and each other, and on these shopping and spa trips, we see them reap the benefits of their wealth, living that nebulous Orange County lifestyle (cf. ARELLANO 2008). Social space is continually transformed into meaningful place as the housewives animate landscape.

LANDSCAPE TENSION MAKES PLACE

In television, landscape functions as both cultural product and cultural process to create place through a meaningful process of becoming. At the start of each Orange County show, viewers are presented with spectacular landscapes in establishing shots. Their function is to frame televisual place, to generate a sense of place through geographic realism, and to imbue it with cultural meaning. The narrative, however, unfolds within discourse space. From broadly construed symbolic landscapes, we zoom into the more personal social landscapes of the characters. Viewers accompany characters as place is enacted within a series of specific settings. As we see this lifestyle played out within the landscape, its social spaces become meaningful and Orange County emerges as a place to viewers. Landscape as space creates place through this process. Viewers are continually reminded of the existence and meaning of this place through repeated presentation of spectacular landscapes in transitional shots throughout each episode.

Thus, central to place-making in television is the ongoing tension between landscape as space and place, as cultural product and process. The second episode of *The OC* provides an illustration. The episode begins with a broad presentation of Orange County as a lucrative setting through a series of ocean and beach shots. These give way to a stunning aerial view of coastal mansions, and next the camera has zoomed in on the Cohen's house. Finally, we cut to Seth and Ryan lounging in the pool (Figure 54). At the pool, the episode's narrative commences, concluding this classic progression from "the general to the particular" (HIGSON 1984: 7). As HIGSON (1984: 7) explains,

the [scalar] movement from one image to the next rapidly impregnates the space, after each transition, with increasing narrative significance and dramatic purpose, until finally the individual is placed in his environment, as a figure in the landscape.



Figure 54. *Place to space in The OC*

This progression is “a classical movement from the general to the particular” (HIGSON 1984, 7), and it works on two levels. First, this movement embodies the tension within landscape as a cultural product and as a process. As a product, we are presented with a general way of seeing. As a cultural process, landscape unfolds through the ongoing assemblages of people, places, experiences, actions, and dialogue. Secondly, the movement from the general to the specific is a compositional technique accomplished through “the establishment of fixed patterns of clarity for the variation of scale of shots in a scene” (HEATH 1981, 41). The scalar transition “is of extreme importance attached to providing an overall view, literally the ‘master shot’ [establishing shot] that will allow the scene to be dominated in the course of its reconstitution narratively as dramatic unity” (HEATH 1981, 41).

After a brief set of scenes alternating between the social spaces of the Cohen home and pool, the opening sequence re-establishes Orange County through spectacular landscapes as a beautiful, privileged place (Figure 39). After a commercial break, we re-enter Orange County and are re-oriented with a shot of the pool house where Ryan resides. The next shot is of Ryan tossing and turning in his bed. The narrative continues as viewers are drawn into the social space of Ryan’s current dilemma. At other points in the episode, transitional shots of the Cohen home and other locations reinforce our sense of place before action resumes. The progression and assemblage of different landscape functions (from the general to the specific, from description to narration, from place to space and back again) in each episode and throughout the course of these series constructs televisual place.

The process of place-making as experienced by television viewers is articulated by ROSE’s (2006, 547) definition of landscape as a dream of presence:

Conceptualizing the cultural landscape as a dream of presence means understanding it as an unfolding plane of sensory, affective, or perceptual markers registering and, thus, effecting the emergence of subjectivity.

Televisual landscapes of Orange County enable place to unfold through viewers' affective response to the lives played out within. Although we will never find ourselves truly within the televisual world of Ryan and Seth or the housewives (an "impossible possibilit[y]" [ROSE 2006, 545]), we can imagine our presence in Orange County as we engage with this setting and feel it becoming closer and more familiar – that is, becoming a place – with each episode watched. Viewers use the televisual landscape to "imagine, cultivate, and move towards [the TV] world ... as present and, in the process, to experience it more intensively" (ROSE 2006, 549).

THE MEDIUM OF TELEVISION

It is apparent that the medium of television has much to offer the study of place-making, although the portrayal of place in cinema has garnered much more attention within media geography for several reasons. First, as outlined in chapter one, the TV screen is smaller than a movie screen and, in older models, squarer and unable to accommodate panoramic shots that emphasize landscape. Whereas movies tend to be viewed in total darkness with few distractions, TV programs are fragmented, interrupted by commercials, and are often not the sole focus of the viewer's attention (HIGSON 1987; ADAMS 1992). Additionally, TV shows are shorter in duration than movies, with only 20–40 minutes (after commercials) in which to tell their story. Due to time constraints, constraints of the viewing frame, and lower production budgets, geographic realism is not always a priority in TV. Television generally emphasizes action occurring within social space over the broader landscape meanings (landscape as place, spectacle, and metaphor) that cinema more often employs. Development of place on TV most often occurs speedily and thriftily, with the use of only a few establishing shots. These characteristics of television viewing are assumed to reduce television's ability to utilize landscape in the construction of place.

This trio of shows does much to negate these arguments. *Laguna Beach*, a ground-breaking show in many ways, disproves the notion that televisual landscapes are necessarily less stunning than those on the big screen. *Laguna Beach*, like cinema, is shot with a widescreen aspect ratio and elaborate lighting configurations, so that "blonde hair and tanned skin emit an especially painterly glow" (MCCARTHY 2004), or so that "every frame ... looks like it has been dipped in honey" (ROCHLIN 2005). The growing popularity of widescreen high-definition TV sets will undoubtedly encourage a trend toward increased use of panoramic landscapes on television. Additionally, reality TV has become popular with networks because it is economical (non-actors, no sets). Thus, in this genre, more resources may become available to interweave the broader place-based meanings expressed by spectacular or metaphorical landscape with the micro-level social spaces already present in reality programming.

In all three shows, Orange County holds the title role; their premises depend upon scripting evocative meaning onto this place. During a period when many

shows, in the interest of time, have dispensed with title sequences and theme songs (PEYSER 2005), or reduced them to a logo shown for a few seconds with a few notes of music. *The OC* and *Laguna Beach* use their opening credits to introduce place to great effect. Unlike in the movies, these sequences are seen week after week and sense of place is reinforced through repetition with each viewing. Time accrued through the course of a season allows landscape to build and maintain televisual place.

The strength of television's place-making power thus lies in its episodic and repetitive structure. Fans visit the TV world on a weekly basis, often over a period of years. As described by BRUNO (2007, 39–40), fans are nourished by the familiarity of this place and its landscapes, and these satisfy the desire for voyeuristic travel:

Cultures and individuals fixate on specific landscapes for different reasons and reactively pursue them. A traveler seeking a particular landscape may go there, even filmically, to be replenished, restored, held, and fed. In the hub of traveling and dwelling, we are absorbed in the stream of emotions and experience an embracing affective transport.

The OC aired 104 episodes over its four-year run; *Laguna Beach* (including its short-lived spin-off, *Newport Harbor*) ran fifty-eight; and, *The Real Housewives* eighty-two episodes in six seasons (and counting). The hours, weeks, and years encompassed by the span of a series allow significantly *more* time for landscape to do its work and for place-making to occur than does a movie viewed only once. Landscapes of television play to our topophilic and scopophilic desires, allowing the places they create to become an integral part of our daily lived experience (LUKINBEAL 2005). Televisual place-making is, therefore, a dynamic and ongoing process which unfolds as we watch and wait to return.

In this chapter, we have described the ways in which landscape contributes to the place-making process and works to create televisual Orange County. The next chapter explores the connection viewers forge to place within the social spaces of television. To do so, we address the emotional component of televisual place as communicated through the genres of melodrama and reality TV.

CHAPTER 5

EMOTIONAL REALISM

As we have seen in chapter four, landscape provides the milieu within which televisual place unfolds. It is via these homes, restaurants, and spas that we forge a connection to the characters, their lives, and the places they inhabit. This chapter further addresses the place-making process as it occurs within narrative space by exploring the concept of emotional realism within the primetime soap opera and dramatic reality television. After establishing the role of emotional realism in televisual place-making, we conclude by offering a means of conceptualizing the televisual experience.

EMOTIONAL REALISM AND THE PRIMETIME SOAP OPERA

The OC is best described as a primetime soap, among the latest in a genre that the massively popular Reagan-era sagas *Dallas* and *Dynasty* introduced. In the 1990s, the genre's subject shifted from wealthy patriarchal families to wealthy teens and young adults with *Beverly Hills 90210* and *Melrose Place* (FEUER 1995). As evidenced by this lineup, U.S. soaps tend to attract viewers with their depiction of an aspirational lifestyle in congruence with the American Dream (JHALLY and LEWIS 1992). As such, these popular programs share an opulence of setting, an excess in the melodramatic tradition (FEUER 1995): a fancy ranch in oil-rich Dallas, the lavish mansions and automobiles enjoyed by *Dynasty's* ruling family, the trendy halls of West Beverly High, and of course, Orange County's yachts and oceanfront property.

Primetime soaps differ from daytime soaps in their weekly broadcast, higher production values, and increased attention to visual excess, but are similar in their melodramatic nature (ANG 1985). The soap opera, or serial melodrama, operates upon a "heightened emotional register" and can be identified by several characteristics (JOYRICH 1996, 51). First, these programs feature several storylines across a "community" of characters. Second, they focus on the private, personal lives of these characters, leaving much of their participation in the public sphere untold (ANG 1985). Finally, the characters of melodrama are trapped aboard a never-ending emotional roller coaster; they are continuously bombarded with devastating news, emergencies, and tumultuous relationships (ANG 1985; JOYRICH 1996). Until the series finale, there is no conclusion and nary a happily ever after.

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The results of several reception studies suggest that much of the pleasure derived from watching television stems from a degree of realism present in its programming (cf. ANG 1985; JHALLY and LEWIS 1992). If a show contains something that viewers can believe in, or relate to, they are more likely to suspend their disbelief, abandon their doubts, and become more thoroughly immersed in the televisual experience. As discussed in the previous chapter, landscape constructs a setting within which the drama takes place (LUKINBEAL 2006). But this is only one part of the equation. For a program to be truly enjoyable, the viewer must also identify with the characters and their situations. In the words of ANG (1985, 20; paraphrasing Bourdieu), "popular pleasure is first and foremost a pleasure of recognition."

Their intricate storylines, unrelenting drama, and alarming number of amorous relationships within the character community make soaps seem, at first blush, quite unrealistic and campy; they are often derided in terms of their far-fetched theatrics. Accordingly, ANG's (1985) study of *Dallas* questions the immense popularity of this show. Through viewer responses to the question of why they enjoy watching *Dallas*, ANG (1985, 45) finds that the appeal of the series, and melodrama in general, lies in what she terms "emotional realism." Many elements of melodrama are unrealistic on a denotative, or literal, level but are recognizable at a connotative level as associated meanings. Rather than by an empirical realism measuring a text's accurate reproduction of reality, fans judge melodrama by its ability to evoke emotions. Often in television, states ANG (1985, 45), "... what is recognized as real is not knowledge of the world, but a subjective experience of the world ..."

The emotional realism of melodrama is built upon a "tragic structure of feeling" (ANG 1985, 46) or a "complex of meanings" (ANG 1985, 61) which evoke the never-ending search for happiness that characterizes life. Melodrama exaggerates these highs and lows for emotional effect. Characters endure countless traumas as if such frequency were normal, and viewers read these as metaphors for their own "life's torments" (ANG 1985, 63). Alcoholism, for example, is an oft-used plot device in both *Dallas* and *The OC*. In such shows, heavy drinking is not so much addressed concretely, as the disease it is, but functions to symbolize a character's suffering and fragile emotional state. Regular viewers of this genre readily interpret the metaphor and lend it emotional significance (ANG 1985). Fan responses illustrate *Dallas*' emotional impact:

The reason I like watching it is that it's nice to get dizzy on their problems ... I really enjoy having a good cry with them. And why not? In this way my other bottled-up emotions find an outlet (ANG 1985, 49).

It is easier and loads more pleasurable to dash away a tear because Ma Dallas has cancer - because she's only acting - than because of whatever annoying things are in your own life, and at least you have got rid of that tear (ANG 1985, 50).

ANG (1985, 79) concludes her analysis by explaining how possession of (and openness to) a "melodramatic imagination" is key to taking pleasure in soap opera's emotional realism and its articulation of the feelings we don't often have

the means or opportunity to express. This is why some like to watch *Dallas* and other shows of its ilk:

The melodramatic imagination should be regarded as a psychological strategy to overcome the material meaninglessness of everyday existence, in which routine and habit prevail ... In other words it is a matter of making the "world we inhabit one charged with meaning" ... The melodramatic imagination is therefore the expression of a refusal, or inability, to accept insignificant everyday life as banal and meaningless, and is born of a vague, inarticulate dissatisfaction with existence here and now. This then is the tragic structure of feeling: it is not about the great suffering which plays such a prominent role in the history of humankind ... but is rather about what is usually not acknowledged as tragic at all and for that very reason is so difficult to communicate. There are no words for the ordinary pain of living of ordinary people ... for the vague sense of loss ... By making that ordinariness something special and meaningful in the imagination, that sense of loss can—at least for a time—be removed. It is in this world of the imagination that watching melodramatic soap operas can be pleasurable: *Dallas* offers a starting point for the melodramatic imagination, nourishes it, makes it concrete (ANG 1985, 79–80).

According to ANG (1985, 82), *Dallas* penetrates viewers' "imaginative world" and "connects up with one of the ways in which [viewers] encounter life." Specifically:

In so far as the imagination is an essential component of our psychological world, the pleasure of *Dallas* ... is not a *compensation* for the presumed drabness of daily life, nor a *flight* from it, but a *dimension* of it ... a life without imagination does not exist (ANG 1985, 83) (Figure 55).



Figure 55. Pamela (Victoria Principal), following a spat with husband Bobby on *Dallas*

In ANG's (1985) view, the emotionally-elevated world of TV melodrama grips our imagination and in so doing, becomes an integral part of everyday experience. We long for feelings of emotional affect and willingly "play along," actively appropriating personal meaning from TV's mass message. Emotional realism extends our lived world to encompass these televisual places, allowing us to join a new community and to participate in its place-making. Place is created as these emotions are emplaced and, with time, built up within the social spaces of a

television series. Melodrama is designed to draw viewers into its world, and its world into our lives.

Yet, emotional realism works on two levels: it concurrently allows participation in place-making, while also offering disengagement – a way out – from the tricky situations implicated in this process. Emotional realism simultaneously connects viewers to televisual place while also sheltering viewers from the effects of emotional entanglement. We could hardly survive a life so filled with drama, yet characters' constant upheavals pleasurably expand our affective experience. We are simultaneously insiders and outsiders in the televisual world. We emotionally engage with televisual place, yet these places remain "dreams of presence" (ROSE 2002, 547) within the melodramatic imagination. We may experience the emotional climax of *The OC*'s season one finale (see synopsis in chapter three), or "dash away a tear" with "Ma Dallas" (ANG 1985, 50) but, when we are ready, we can also forget about Ma Dallas' troubles and return to our quotidian existence. This is, undoubtedly, an alluring aspect of participation in televisual place.

REALITY TV

Reality TV exploded onto American airwaves in the new millennium. The breadth of shows under the reality umbrella include *Bachelor*-style dating shows, to *Survivor* and *American Idol*-type competitions, to voyeuristic "episodic reality soaps" which offer a window onto the lives of celebrities or other people of interest; *The Real Housewives* and *Laguna Beach* fall under the latter category (HOLMES and JERMYN 2004, 6). All reality shows share characteristics of minimal writing and the casting of, if not exactly "regular folks," at least non-actors. News and documentaries are excluded from this genre because in reality TV, "access to the real is presented in the name of dramatic uncertainty, voyeurism, and popular pleasure," rather than public service, education, or more altruistic goals (OUELLETTE and MURRAY 2004, 2). Though in name the genre implies a more realistic portrayal of the people and situations it depicts than overtly fictional sitcoms and soaps, much evidence points to the contrary. The "real" in reality TV is instead an "entertaining real" (OUELLETTE and MURRAY 2004, 4) or a "popular reality" (HARTLEY 1996, as cited in CORNER 2002, 268). As FRIEDMAN (2002, 8) explains, "What is new and fresh about these programs is not their allegiance to reality but the marriage of reality conventions with dramatic structure."

In fact, the appeal of reality entertainment owes much to the conventions of melodrama. The "real" people cast in these shows are placed in contrived situations created for maximum conflict and suspense: either trapped on an island to compete for one million dollars (*Survivor*) (Figure 56), picked to live in a house with seven strangers (*The Real World*), or entrenched in competition for the affections of the perfect guy (*The Bachelor*). MCCARTHY (2004, 1) observes: "reality TV remains firmly within the realm of melodrama, dependent for its

appeal on the ability of characters to externalize emotions and internal conflicts through speech, expressions, and gestures.”



Figure 56. Recent *Survivor* cast members

Although the situations in episodic reality soaps are not so obviously contrived as those of “gamedocs” like *Survivor*, much of their drama is in fact created in the editing room. MTV’s successful series *The Osbournes*, “the first reality sitcom,” as KOMPARE (2004, 107) points out, chronicles the family life of aging rocker Ozzy Osbourne in a manner drawing heavily from the conventions of traditional fictional sitcoms (Figure 57). Hours of footage were edited into cohesive twenty-minute episodes within which “problems are introduced, conflicts play out, and the end of the episode reaches a mild resolution” (KOMPARE 2004, 108).

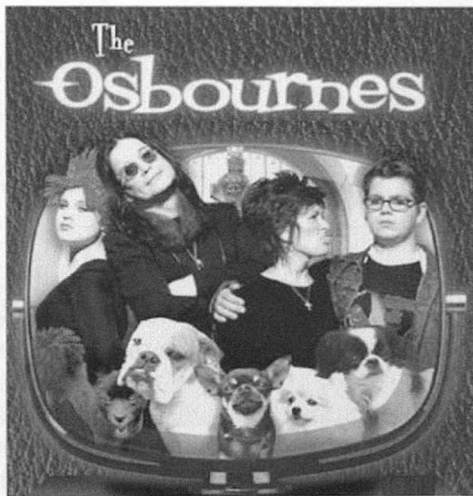


Figure 57. *The Osbournes* (2002)

In the case of reality soaps like *The Real Housewives* and *Laguna Beach*, subjects are “cast and planned as carefully as in any fiction” (KOMPARE 2004, 106).

Reality producers search for “telegenic” people who look and are prone to act in ways which fall within the visually pleasing and dramatic norms of the medium (i.e. people who are both good-looking *and* emotional) (KOMPARE 2004, 106). Also, just as *The Osbournes* accomplished in sitcom style, editors of these shows advantageously use known conclusions to construct episodes containing the pleasurable codes of melodrama (FRIEDMAN 2002). In *Housewives*, for example, some storylines are contained within one episode, such as Jeana buying her daughter a new car, and others build toward a crescendo. Episodes often end on an uncertain note, and as promised in previews, we will continue to follow this issue in the next episode. To illustrate, the big story in the first season of *Housewives* is the tenuous nature of housewife Jo’s relationship with her fiancé, Slade, and the season ends with their break up (Figure 58). Previous episodes lead to that climax by emphasizing Jo’s boredom and desire to establish her own career, as well as Jo’s proclivity to “go out with the girls.” A local critic comments:

I think we all know that Scott Dunlop [*Housewives* creator] could never have sold a show about his hometown had he focused on the mundane lives these women lead much of the time (MICKADEIT 2006c).

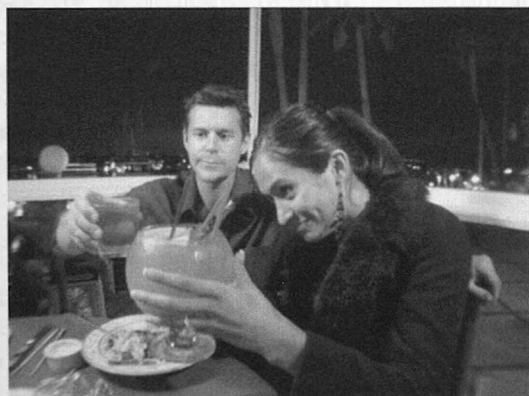


Figure 58. A tense moment in Jo and Slade’s relationship

The Real Housewives is a staid member of the reality genre, and it thus utilizes another convention of reality TV: the use of videotaped interviews which provide a character’s description and explanation of the situation after-the-fact. Because there is no script, these interviews fill in narrative gaps that the footage cannot be edited to express (MCCARTHY 2004). Emotional realism on reality TV is thus composed in this manner: Cast members emplace their drama by acting within social space; they later explain their feelings to the camera; editing molds material into episodes conforming to television norms that viewers readily understand and are primed to identify with; and ultimately, viewers become ensconced in Orange County. Each episode builds upon this formula to construct televisual place.

Laguna Beach, proclaimed the first “reality drama,” differs considerably from shows like *The Real Housewives* (CHANG 2004), not only in its cinematic look.

Although the text contained in its opening screen (and subtitle: *The Real Orange County*) firmly presents the show as within the reality genre (Figure 59), *Laguna Beach* much more resembles traditional melodrama in structure. It does not utilize the interview-narrative format and, as MCCARTHY (2004) further observes:

... many scenarios are clearly staged for the camera. We see teenage boys squirm and mumble as they endeavor to carry on a group conversation on a set topic: will they stay in touch after graduation? And we witness both ends of telephone conversations, a strategy that signals the show's commitment to narrative form and continuity over the pretense of spontaneous action. These staged moments position the teenage cast as improvising actors rather than sociological subjects. Together with the show's lush cinematography, they forge a connection between *Laguna Beach*'s "real Orange County" and the dramatic show it aims to supplement: Fox's lavishly shot teen soap hit *The OC* (Figure 60).

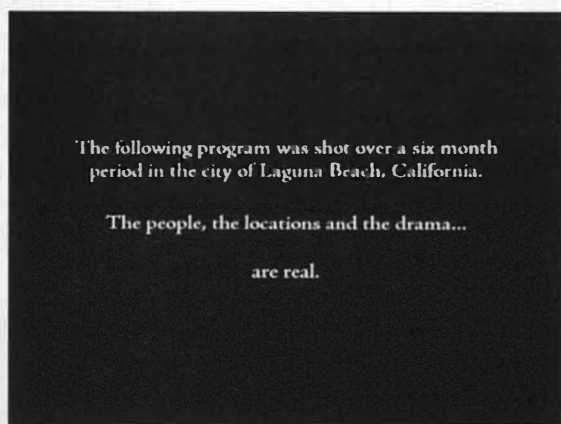


Figure 59. *Laguna Beach*'s claim to the real

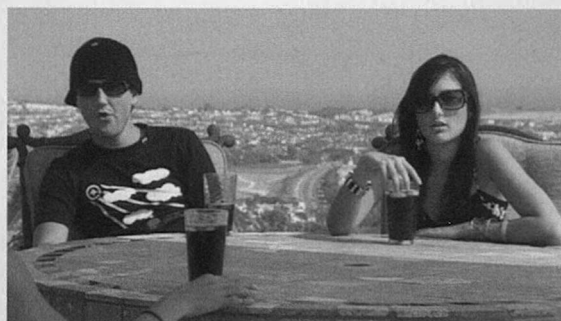


Figure 60. Typical *Laguna*: discussing the evening's plans against a stunning backdrop

Several devices are used to promote emotional realism in the melodramatic genre: a reliance upon emotive music, in lieu of speech, to express characters' deepest feelings; close-up shots linger a few seconds after the last line of dialogue in a scene is uttered in order to emphasize the emotion contained in the actor's facial

expression; and rather than attempting to portray the nuanced complexity of many “real-life” personalities and situations, characters and the decisions they make are painted in easy-to-read oppositions of good versus evil and right versus wrong (FEUER 1995; JOYRICH 1996).

These generic devices are put to work within the social landscapes of *Laguna Beach*. *Laguna Beach* viewers participate in an emotionally-charged place-making process more similar to that of *The OC* than *The Real Housewives*. Frequent use of musical montage tells a good deal of the story in each episode (MTV’s *Laguna Beach* mix is available for purchase on iTunes), as does the “liberal inclusion of long close-ups of the characters’ relatively blank faces” (LEVINE 2006) (Figure 61). LEVINE (2006) additionally notes that, as in daytime soaps, nothing really happens in any given episode of *Laguna Beach*. “Instead, each episode revolves around ‘drama’ (the kids’ favorite word ...) which has the vague meaning of some kind of conflict or emotional upheaval,” usually involving the show’s infamous “not-entirely-there” love triangle (LEVINE 2006). The many conversations we witness at restaurants and the beach “work to force a plot around a sequence of somewhat disconnected events and characters” (LEVINE 2006) (Figure 62).



Figure 61. Lauren’s thoughts drift from the bon fire



Figure 62. Jason and Jessica conclude their tumultuous relationship in season two

As an astute commenter on LEVINE’s (2006) (online) article observes, however, the “thinness” of the characters and lack of strong narrative content “imitates the banality of real life.” In a way, the emotional realism of this “reality drama” is heightened by the normalcy of events it depicts – chatting with friends, dating,

getting pedicures, going to prom. If, as ANG (1985) argues, primetime soaps draw their appeal from identification with characters' emotional reactions to over-the-top situations, then *Laguna Beach*, in its "meaning without meaning" (LEVINE 2006) manages to imbue less meaningful situations with a similar emotionality. Orange County is associated with a powerful affective response, a result impossible without music. LUKINBEAL and ZIMMERMANN (2008, 21) explain:

Audio guides our affective response. It saturates film and ... gives space depth through emotive becoming, and guides the unconscious experiential musings of the mind. It calls on our subjectivity to react to seen, heard, felt, and experienced memories and emotions. The assemblage of audio-video takes us on a voyage through ourselves as much as through the film's narrative.

Therefore, reality TV does not mean more realistic narratives or more realism; its contrived situations, carefully constructed episodes, and *Laguna's* music-based affect are evidence that reality TV draws its appeal not so much from a more accurate portrayal of everyday life, but rather from devotion to melodramatic conventions linked to emotional realism. In short, *Laguna Beach*, as compared to *The OC*, is more akin to high school as imagined (paraphrasing BELLAFANTE 2007). In contrast to the excessive world of fictional soaps, the banality of reality programming offers a means of place-making writ small, which occurs through a focus on interpersonal relations, built over time, within a familiar social landscape (Figure 63).

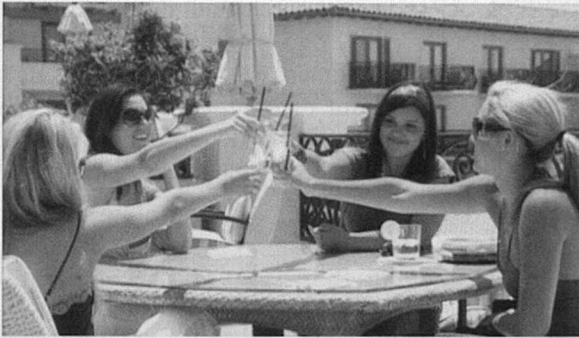


Figure 63. *The senior girls toast high school memories*

Both the primetime and reality soap are designed to resonate with viewers on an emotional level, and this emotional realism is integral to the place-making process. Landscape contributes to this process by establishing geographic realism, which allows the social spaces of the narrative to "take place." Landscape links cultural meanings, stereotypes, and icons to emotional realism. Emotional realism, as conveyed through conventions of melodrama within the social landscape, generates a powerful affective response, emplaces these sensations, and expands the reach of our lived experience. This engagement creates "the OC" as a meaningful place, and this connection builds and strengthens with each episode watched, each hour spent there. The experience of watching TV involves far more

than just seeing, for film and television are not simply images on a screen, but “an assemblage of sight and sound, of texture and (e)motion, memory and experience” (LUKINBEAL and ZIMMERMANN 2008, 15).

THE REALITY OF TV

Despite the claims of reality TV to represent life (in place) as it actually unfolds, viewers are well aware that much of its content is made-for-TV (HILL 2002; OUELLETTE and MURRAY 2004). Both primetime and reality soaps are fabricated forms, and so rely upon similar expressions of realism – geographic realism to convince viewers to suspend their disbelief and to construct the spaces and places of narrative action, and emotional realism to thoroughly engage viewers within, making televisual place “matter.” Thus, the paradox of television is that “we know that these characters are not real, yet we gain pleasure from them in part because they *seem* real” (JHALLY and LEWIS 1992, 22). We are fully aware of television’s fiction, but its realism allows it to become a reality that matters and is meaningful in our daily lives.

When asked to judge the realism of *The Cosby Show*, the popular 1980s sitcom, participants in JHALLY and LEWIS’ (1992, 28) reception study frequently commented that the show was both “very realistic” and “totally unbelievable” (Figure 64). ANG’s (1985, 50) audience survey also indicates “a constant to and fro movement between identification with and distancing from the fictional world ...” JHALLY and LEWIS (1992) go on to posit that lacking enough direct experience upon which to base a judgment or form an opinion, the mediated world fills this gap; we use it to build our own *musée imaginaire*. Citing a study by PRESS (1991, 163) as evidence, when a female respondent is asked to compare a female attorney she once met with Clair Huxtable (matriarch of *The Cosby Show*), she believes in the mediated version:

- Interviewer: *You know one woman attorney. Did she remind of you Clair?*
 Respondent: *No. Not even closely. Because she wasn't as feminine as Clair Huxtable.*
 Interviewer: *Who do you think is more typical of women attorneys?*
 Respondent: *Clair Huxtable.*
 Interviewer: *Why?*
 Respondent: *Well, because I've seen other ones on television like on the news and things like that and they are all more feminine than the one I knew.*



Figure 64. Cast of *The Cosby Show* (1984)

This response is a remarkable example of the power of television to influence perception and the undeniable attraction of television's simplified, stereotyped, and exaggerated depictions of people and place. JHALLY and LEWIS (1992, 30) reach a straightforward, yet important conclusion: "We can no longer assume that the content of TV fiction does not matter simply because TV viewers understand that it is fiction." In short, our judgments and opinions are not always based on a strict distinction between "fact" and "fiction;" more often than not, this line is blurred by the media.

In a subsequent article, LEWIS (2004) expands upon these findings to offer a compelling reconsideration of how we qualify direct versus secondhand experience. He begins by recognizing, as does ANG (1985), that television is an integral component of our everyday experience:

We cannot systematically pluck those hours of the day we spend watching it and disregard them as nothing more than a vicarious, secondhand class of experience. When we turn off the TV we do not suddenly return to a more vivid [or less vivid in the case of TV images], less ephemeral space (LEWIS 2004, 292).

Instead, just as life is not lived without imagination (ANG 1985), the mediated and the material coexist, overlap, and are routinely juxtaposed: "we eat dinner, watch TV, talk about TV, do the dishes ... it is part of us, and we feel that we are part of it" (LEWIS 2004, 295).

Furthermore, as LEWIS (2004) implies above, and as the personal nature of emotional identification with melodrama suggests, watching TV is not a vicarious experience of material place, but a direct experience of mediated place. This view is supported by KIM and RICHARDSON's (2003) reception study of Vienna, Austria through the film *Before Sunrise* (Figure 65). KIM and RICHARDSON (2003) had

hypothesized that viewers would experience Vienna vicariously, through empathetic involvement with the film's characters, but instead found that empathy had little to do with the changes in viewers' perception of this place. They conclude that

more direct (rather than vicarious) participation with a place may occur through movie viewing. That is, subjects may feel that they are personally and more directly drawn into the 'presence' of a place, rather than experiencing it through the eyes of another (KIM and RICHARDSON 2003, 231).

Instead, we experience place through the camera's eye which "has penetrated so deeply into reality" that it presents "an aspect of reality which is free of all equipment" (BENJAMIN 1968, 233–234). The camera's eye is the same as our own; its presence is our presence.

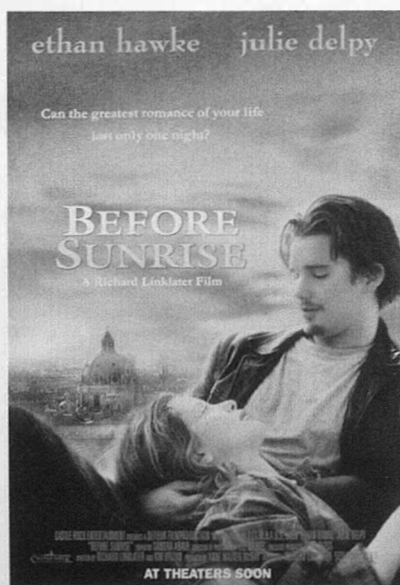


Figure 65. Before Sunrise (1995)

In 1973, a documentary-style program called *An American Family* was produced by PBS as a sociological experiment. Often cited as the first reality show, this exercise in cinema vérité filmed Santa Barbara's Loud family in their home over a period of several months (OUELLETTE and MURRAY 2004) (Figure 66). The novelty of this program prompted BAUDRILLARD (1994, 28) to describe the paradox of directly experiencing mediated place:

The producer's triumph was to say: "They lived as if we were not there." An absurd, paradoxical formula – neither true nor false: utopian. The "as if we were not there" being equal to "as if you were there. It is this utopia, this paradox that fascinated the twenty million viewers, much more than did the "perverse" pleasure of violating someone's privacy. In the "vérité" experience it is not a question of secrecy or perversion, but of a sort of frisson of the real, or of an aesthetics of the hyperreal, a frisson of vertiginous and phony exactitude, a frisson of

simultaneous distancing and magnification, of distortion of scale, of an excessive transparency. The pleasure of an excess of meaning, when the bar of the sign falls below the usual waterline of meaning: the nonsignifier is exalted by the camera angle. There one sees what the real never was (but “as if you were there”), without the distance that gives us perspectival space and depth vision (but “more real than nature”).



Figure 66. *The Louds of An American Family* (1973)

In the case of television or film, we experience voyeuristic pleasures when viewing a spectacular establishing shot of the Laguna Beach coastline, as well the haptical pleasures of being present at an intimate scene. Our televisual experience is not limited to the optical plane, but also includes the anti-optical, or experience that is directly felt as we accompany characters on their narrative journey through place. Filmic allure moves between the optical and the haptical; we are granted the pleasures of being the omnipresent voyeur and simultaneously the pleasures of engaging with people, places, and situations through our own experiences, feelings, and emotions. Thus, a television program is the culmination of melodramatic production techniques designed to promote emotional realism and to evoke a sensory reaction – a uniquely televisual experience of place through its screen. The emotions and sensations we feel through our active personal and meaningful engagement produce a gathering place.

Upon visiting the U.S., BAUDRILLARD (1988, 104) proclaimed, “The cinema and TV are America’s reality!” Indeed, television expands our experience in and of place, and this experience is a part of our everyday lives. To paraphrase SCHOENKOPF (2008), if perception is reality, then *The Real Housewives* show us the real Orange County. Through the place-making process, television is transformed into real virtuality, not merely an image of the real world, but experience itself. While the experience of physically being in a place and watching that place on TV are epistemologically different, they are ontologically the same. Place is always a way of knowing the world and a meaningful experience in it, and integrally, place-making is always a process: “... a viewer’s participation in a film is dynamic and continually changing as the text evolves, and with the work of narrative convention” (AITKEN and ZONN 1994, 20). We live in film, and film lives in us (KENNEDY 2008).

EMOTIONAL AND GEOGRAPHIC REALISM

In this and the previous chapter, we have explored the creation of place on TV. The production techniques involved in creating a sense of both emotional and geographic realism constitute the processes of place-making initiated by the medium (rather than the audience). Realism, of both types, is the key to suspension of disbelief and subsequent audience engagement with the televisual world. As discussed in chapter four, landscape as place and spectacle, as seen in establishing shots, the opening credits, and transitional shots of a television show, serves to script and establish geographic realism, enticing viewers to believe in this place and to inscribe it with certain cultural attributes.

The large-scale landscapes which introduce place at the beginning of a show soon fall away to smaller-scale narrative space, within which emotional realism becomes the dominant mode of place-making. Through the camera's eye, we are present within these social spaces and are haptically drawn into place through an emotional resonance engendered by hearing intimate conversations and seeing expressions in close-up, by participating, emotionally, in the televisual world.

After a commercial break, or between scenes, we again find ourselves in a "position of visual mastery" (HIGSON 1984, 19), gazing upon spectacular landscape in a transitional shot. After a moment, we are brought back into narrative space and into the presence of place. We are no longer gazing upon televisual place, but actively experiencing it. Described in chapter four as a progression between landscape as space and place and back again, the continuous scalar movement between the conventions of geographic and emotional realism is what makes televisual place. Broad meanings contained in the large-scale landscapes that express geographic realism ground the personal meaningfulness engendered by emotional realism, as felt within the small-scale social spaces of the television world. The constant ebb and flow of geographic and emotional realism, cultural meaning and personal meaningfulness, or in Orange County, the interchange of shots of the beach with interpersonal scenes in homes, restaurants, and hot tubs, compose and comprise televisual place.

This chapter has shown that televisual place is not limited to the visibility of its landscapes, but also includes the emotional, haptical, and affective response of our lived world. Place-making, even through television, is a panoply of direct experiences. This and the previous chapter have demonstrated the processes by which the production techniques of geographic and emotional realism create televisual place, but place-making, in the end, is dependent upon viewer engagement. The next chapter engages the processes of televisual place-making from an audience perspective.

CHAPTER 7

WHEN WORLDS COLLIDE: THE PARADOX OF TV TOURISM

The Orange County presented to televiewing audiences is exquisite in its beauty and quite seductive in its composition of sunshine, terraced mansions, and trips to the spa. It is also very dramatic and its social spaces are super-charged with affective resonance. Upon visiting Orange County in person, however, no matter how beautiful one might find its physical environment, how spectacular its mansions, or how much money its residents might throw around, direct experience in a locale cannot be equated with mediated place experience. The Orange County we see on TV is, after all, not true life, but true simulation. Although the nature of experience in both is essentially the same (both are real and direct), they produce dissimilar affects and effects. When a fan visits Orange County in search of "the OC," the resulting collision is that of two places in one location.

HYPERREALITY

Film and television images do not reflect an underlying truth or represent a reproducible reality; instead, they create their own (AITKEN and ZONN 1994; CLARKE 1997; DOEL and CLARKE 2007). Moreover, television's reality is hyperreality, a more-than-real or "realer-than-real" world, modeled not on an original, but in the image of image (BEST and KELLNER 1991, 119; cf. BAUDRILLARD 1983). It is a real "retouched and refurbished," often offering a more stimulating experience than the alternative (BEST and KELLNER 1991, 119; BEST and KELLNER 1997). Such hyperreal circumstances are best illustrated by ECO (1983) when his *Travels in Hyperreality* take him to (none other than) Orange County. ECO (1983, 44) observes of Disneyland's Jungle Cruise ride:

When there is a fake ... it is not so much because it wouldn't be possible to have a real equivalent but because the public is meant to admire the perfection of the fake ... In this sense Disneyland not only produces illusion, but – in confessing it – stimulates the desire for it; A real crocodile can be found in the zoo, and as a rule it is dozing or hiding, but Disneyland tells us that faked nature corresponds much more to our daydream demands ... Disneyland tells us that technology can give us more reality than nature can.

And so, as does Disneyland, TV presents more thrilling, more dramatic, more spectacular, more enthralling places than we encounter in everyday life. SADLER

and HASKINS (2005, 197–198) argue, for example, that several Giuliani-era television programs set in Manhattan, including *Seinfeld*, *Friends*, and *Sex and the City*, offer viewers a postcard-like, tourist-friendly version of the city, a “clean, safe hub of entertainment and consumption” such that with time, “the recurring metonymic representation of the city makes people forget about the real New York” (Figure 67). Similarly, Orange County is commodified and amplified as a succession of beachscapes, cocktail parties, and conspicuous consumption (Figure 68). *The OC*, *Laguna Beach*, and *The Real Housewives* present a hyperreal Orange County which does not aim to reproduce, or even to misrepresent, the locale of Orange County. Rather, it creates a simulated Orange County, or “the OC.” Television has bestowed this hipper nomenclature upon its simulation which, significantly, has never been part of its residents’ vernacular. “The OC” signifies a hyperreal place with its own landscapes, icons, values, residents, and associated emotions. Immersion in the simulation – crying alongside the characters as romantic relationships are ended (to musical accompaniment), basking in the same sun at a gorgeous beach – provides an affective, emotional, expertly framed experience in Orange County, much more so than do the mundane activities of driving down the 405 freeway or getting groceries in Newport Beach.



Figure 67. Cast of *Sex and the City* (1998)



Figure 68. Cocktail party in *The OC*

I'LL TAKE "THE OC"!

Offering more scenery, more spectacle, and more drama than any location, the hyperreal OC looms large in the melodramatic imagination. Survey respondents take palpable pleasure in describing a place they either love to hate or love to love. Some of the more colorful descriptions from the Midwestern and fan survey groups include:

Plastic (both in body and credit cards), beautiful facades (of both house and body), but inside things may not be that great.

They project people who are very rich, women who spend their husbands' money, and kids who spend their parents' money, spend lots of time at the beach.

An oceanfront paradise where everyone has sold their soul.

The OC was portrayed as a modern day Eden or a utopian village of wealth and lack of responsibility.

A glamorous sun-drenched paradise. Everybody has everything they want.

It is no wonder, then, that fans often feel compelled to visit a location they've seen on TV or in the movies, "to put themselves in the physical place" of the action (MACIONIS 2004, 91). Film-induced tourism is a well-documented phenomenon (RILEY and VAN DOREN 1992; TOOKE and BAKER 1996; RILEY et al. 1998), and a wide range of push/pull factors bring tourists to filming locations (MACIONIS 1994). In its most extreme form, emotional involvement with a mediated place is so strong that "media pilgrims" embark upon "value-affirming journeys" to fulfill self-actualization motivations (COULDRY 1998, 102; MACIONIS 1994). As BRUNO (2007, 39) observes, filmic place is "charged with layers of topophilic emotions, it is invested with the ability to nourish the self. This psychic process involves making claims and demands on the site." For example, COULDRY (1998, 97) finds that visitors to the set of *Coronation Street*, Britain's longest-running soap, are thrilled to find themselves, at last, "on the 'actual street' ... where they 'actually film.'" COULDRY's (1998) interviews illustrate (Figure 69):

I couldn't believe that I was actually on the spot of the 1983 showdown that rocked the nation, between Ken, Mike, and Deirdre ... I then carried on walking and approached the spot where Ena and Elsie bickered for all those years and even nearly came to blows (98).

From the moment I put my foot on the Street I feel like a star. I start my walk down the Street ... I look through ALL the windows and through ALL letter boxes. I touch the stone cladding of number 9. I feel so happy and trouble free when I walk down the Street ... It is the best thing and most wonderful thing I have ever done (103).

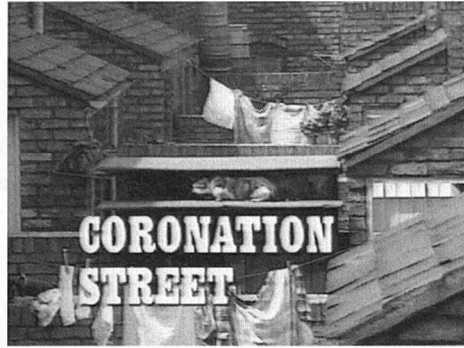


Figure 69. Coronation Street (1960)

These motivations further validate ANG's (1985) concept of emotional realism as integral to viewers' connection with televisual place. Film-induced tourism, as an actual enactment of emotional identification with the world of TV, in anticipation of that magical moment when the normally out-of-reach mediated world intersects our ordinary one (COULDRY 1998), is the ultimate expression of the irresistible attraction of mediated place. Film-induced tourism can be understood as an attempt to procure the haptical, or anti-optical, experiential meaning that emanates from mediated place.

In our hyper-mediated world, there remains a quixotic drive to see the "original," as evidenced by the popularity of art museums or visits to a set or soundstage, to see for ourselves the actual artwork or actual site where filming occurred. In the case of hyperreal televisual place, TV tourists soon realize that the "original" does not exist, but is a myth (LUKINBEAL and ZIMMERMANN 2006). Television excels in composing and simulating a sense of place, but place, as CRESSWELL (2004, 11) explains, is "not just a thing in the world but a way of understanding the world."

For iconic, symbolic locations with a vivid representational legacy, difficult can be the task of living up to the spectacular standard of their "cultural mythology" (STENGER 2001, 61). Not far from Orange County is Hollywood, the place perhaps most idealized in the American psyche and worldwide as center and symbol of the motion picture industry. Hollywood Boulevard, the physical location, is far from our idea of Hollywood from the movies. Since its decline into seediness, the Hollywood and Highland area is now being resurrected as a simulacrum of Hollywood's Golden Age, the focal point of development being a shopping complex designed to look like the iconic movie set, Babylon Court (STENGER 2001). This all to create an experience more satisfying for tourists, a space where "the 'Hollywood' of the imagination may be tangibly validated and consumed" (CURTI et al. 2007, 63). But, as CURTI et al. (2007) note, Babylon Court and its selection of chain stores offer shopping opportunities like any other. The question remains, does even a newly redeveloped "Hollywood" lose its luster when you purchase a pair of jeans at Hollywood and Highland that you could have more easily found at the mall back home (Figure 70)?

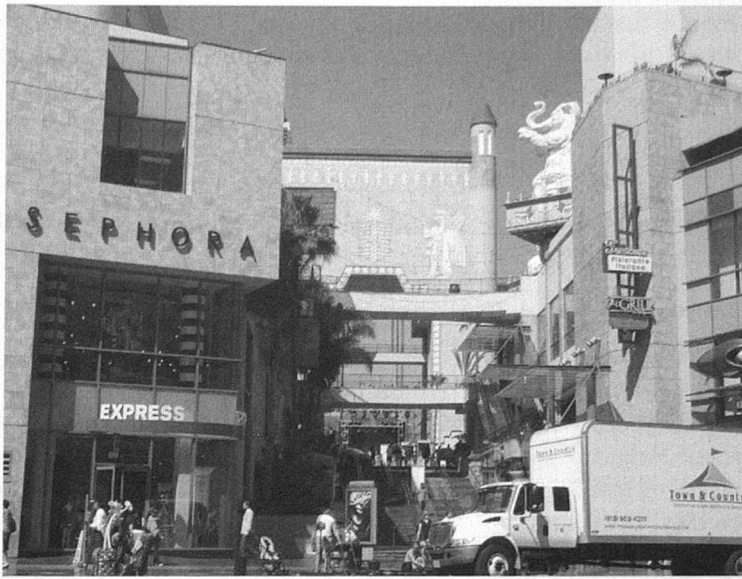


Figure 70. Babylon Court at Hollywood and Highland

JACKSON (2005, 186, citing CROUCH and LÜBBREN 2003), an Englishwoman, relays her disappointing visit to Los Angeles. In her words:

The stars' homes were fascinating, solely because we found them architecturally disappointing ... Visiting the Chinese Theatre brought the realization that whenever this location is filmed ... we see the stars, the red carpet, and the adoring crowd. Yet, immediately adjacent was wasteland, fronted by old railings sporting tacky advertisements, a bleak contrast to the TV-transmitted glitzy glamour ... We made sense of most places by comparing them to screen images, being surprised at our own naivety, having failed to appreciate how extensively our imaginations had been fueled by the "metaphoric construction of ideas and desires."

A *Vanity Fair* columnist ridicules the *Sex and the City* bus tour for a similar reason:

These women on the bus are missing the point. The storyville they're looking for doesn't exist and never did, and trying to search for the literal in literature inevitably kills the object of affection, murders the fiction stone-dead ... After four hours we're dropped off in Midtown. The bus is strangely subdued. The women file out swiftly, each tipping our stand-up guide a grudging, crumpled ten without making eye contact. We all realize what an obsessively ridiculous, embarrassing, empty, and needy exercise this has been. I can't imagine anyone here would repeat the trip, or recommend it to a friend. And I guess that a good many of us will keep it as a guilty secret ... As if to underline our gullibility, they deposit us beside the HBO store (GILL 2009, 53).

Another visitor to the set of *Coronation Street* reflects upon the experience:

It's like when you were a child, you imagine something, then you go back to it as an adult and it's totally different ... it was exactly like that. Everything just seemed very small and flat (COULDRY 2005, 64).

While "the OC" is anything but boring, Orange County survey respondents confirm that a life lived there shares everyday characteristics with everywhere else:

The always exciting and fun aspect isn't true; we're just like everyone else.

My life isn't as dramatic nor as exciting ...

It doesn't show how regular kids live in a house that's three bedrooms or apartments.

We have lives and jobs, real jobs where you actually have to work, and we drive normal cars.

For some reason when it's on TV it seems to be more glamorous.

TORCHIN (2002) uses the Manhattan TV Tour to describe how film can imbue everyday sites with personal significance; however, as these experiences illustrate, when comparing mediated place to the spot at which a tour bus has dropped you, this supposed "original" appears far more ordinary. When expected to provide the glossy images of true hyperreality, even in Orange County, absolute location intrinsically fails to measure up. JACKSON (2005, 194) well-expresses this sentiment, "Our visit to LA demonstrated that when the two collide, disappointment may ensue." By visiting a location with hopes of experiencing the beauty, glamour, and "aura" of mediated place, a curiosity may be satisfied, but essentially, we seek a place that is impossible to find. When we arrive at a site expecting to be enveloped and stimulated by the place we helped to create, we find it absent of affect. Emotional, imaginative, resonate televisual place collides with a location lacking this intimate meaningfulness, and we "inevitably kill the object of *affection*" (GILL 2009, 53; emphasis added).

The idea that cinema and television re-present ontologically stable objects is killed because of the "radical negation of the sign as value" (BAUDRILLARD 1996, 6) – the negation that an absolute location is an equivalent referent to its representation. The re-presented objects, events, and narratives of television and cinema are rarely, if ever, a "sign of reality" (AITKEN and ZONN 1994, 20). The sign is sentenced to death because the simulacrum of television and cinema frees the signified location from its absolute referent. Representation kills affection by limiting the sign to reality, whereas the absent/presences of a simulated place at a filmed location requires the referent to be left open and relative to the affective bond individuals have created with the televisual or cinematic place.

Television's landscapes are more scenic than a drive on the 405 freeway and its emotional realism evokes more feelings than a day spent shopping at one of its malls. Television brings together visual, emotive, musical, and other elements to create places in which meaning is more concentrated, experience is more engaging, and the place-making process more imaginative. Televisual place is, in a word, *more*. To paraphrase ECO (1983), television tells us that its places better correspond to our daydream demands. When someone who has affectively engaged in televisual place-making visits Orange County in search of the mediated place of the same name, he or she is unexpectedly forced to reckon with the paradox of TV tourism. At the very location where we had hoped to re-

experience our televisual place in tangible form, we instead encounter lived regularity. We might find ourselves eating lunch at the very spot where two *Laguna Beach* cast members ate lunch on the show, hoping for a fulfilling experience at the “actual” location, but the screen’s spectacular frame, edited montage, emotive music, and exciting drama are gone. In their place might be noisy traffic, a bad view, and a long wait for food. Lunch here is just lunch, but when experienced alongside the characters, within the hyperreal televisual world, we are emplaced within its social geography, and lunch becomes much more.

THE OC EXPERIENCE

Television exposure has indeed been a boon to tourism in the region, and many fans make the pilgrimage to participate in the “OC” lifestyle they have experienced on TV. Although neither the Newport Beach Convention and Visitors Bureau (NBCVB) nor the Laguna Beach Visitors and Conference Bureau (LBVCB) have formal mechanisms in place to track TV-induced tourism, officials from both organizations feel that visitorship has definitely increased as a result of these shows and can cite significant increases in hits to their websites (BIJLANI 2008; LEONCIO 2008). Area newspapers provide anecdotal evidence of a major tourist influx:

Shopkeepers are swamped with tourists and callers wanting to track down the stars. ‘I’ve spent the last two years saying “Stephen [*Laguna Beach* heartthrob] doesn’t work here,”’ said Thalia Street Surf Shop owner Pam Cocores (SMITH 2005).

People have gone to the high school looking for *Laguna Beach* characters. Out-of-town teens have tried to enroll in the hope of being discovered. There have been minor traffic accidents as motorists gawked at the filming around the city (KELLY 2006).

With the exception of establishing shots, *The OC* was not filmed in the County of Orange. Acutely aware of this problem, the NBCVB created an “As Seen on *The OC*” map to appease star-struck tourists, directing visitors to the spots which inspired many of the locations used in the show (Figure 71). Guests are also encouraged to visit a site (ironically, the front office of an RV park) where handprints of *The OC* cast members can be viewed (Figure 72). Explains a NBCVB official:

... even though they didn’t film here, showing them around the destinations gives them a taste of the lifestyle, because that’s what the show is selling, really, is the lifestyle, the destination, and you still get a feel for that, no matter if you’re really in front of the Cohen house (LEONCIO 2008).

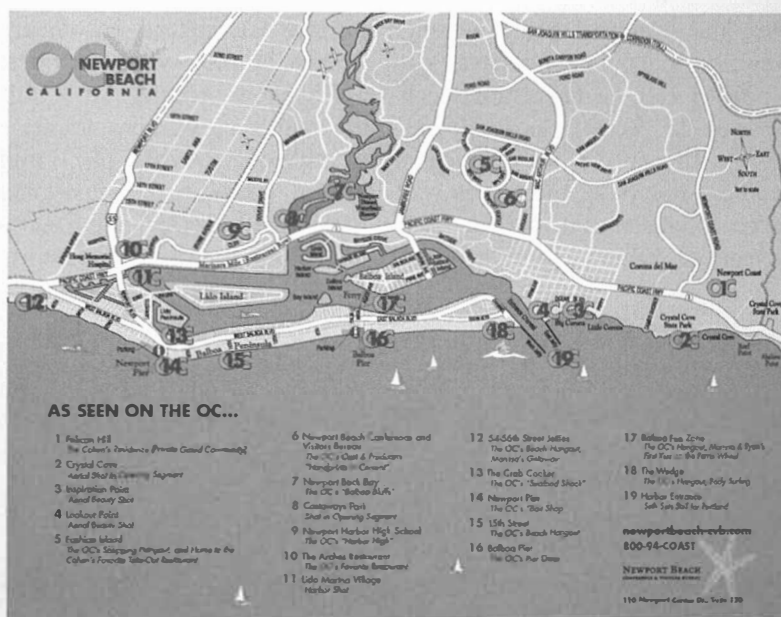


Figure 71. NBCVB's "As Seen on The OC" map. Available from www.visitnewportbeach.com



Figure 72. Handprints of The OC cast as displayed at Newport Dunes Waterfront Resort

Laguna Beach is, of course, filmed on location, but visitors who want to see actual homes of the cast members will be disappointed, as most reside in gated communities that are well beyond the reach of the general public. Laguna Beach High School, which we presume cast members attend (the show contains little mention of school), is easy to find, however, and has become a busy intersection of star-seekers (KELLY 2006) (Figure 73). The LBVCB, for its part, offers visitors a list of filming locations to assist in their search for “the real Orange County,” including shops and eateries that cast members frequent on the series. In the opinion of Judy BIJLANI, Executive Director of the LBVCB, “there might be a level of disappointment not seeing stars walking down the street, but this is mitigated by being here, being submersed in the experience” (BIJLANI 2008). The general industry sense is that TV tourists leave Orange County feeling satisfied, because it has so many other attractions to offer.



Figure 73. The (in)famous *Laguna Beach* High School

While *The OC* craze has died down in the U.S., the show is in syndication abroad and Newport Beach now welcomes many Japanese and other international fans of the show (LEONCIO 2008). To take advantage of the area's newfound popularity with foreign visitors (most of whom also go to Disneyland), Coach USA/Gray Line, since 2005, has offered “The OC Experience” bus tour. Says Belinda TRANI, Director of Sales for the tour, approximately 90% of tour-takers hail from abroad, mostly Canada, Australia, and New Zealand, and most are, in fact, fans of *The OC*, “looking to see where these people may shop, eat, and play. The international visitors are very fascinated with the California lifestyle” (TRANI 2008).

On Tuesday, December 23, 2008, one of the authors (Ann) took the OC Experience tour. Three days per week, the tour departs from Anaheim (Disney central) and visits a handful of Newport Beach points of interest. Along on the tour were a young family from Indiana and two couples in their twenties or early thirties. One couple was from Canada, the other, Australia. Each group had come to Orange County specifically to visit Disneyland and other area theme parks, but were lured to this tour by promise of its proximity to the beach and opulent mansions, as advertised in the Southern California Gray Line promotional brochure:

Escape for a day to world renown Newport Beach, crown jewel of the California Riviera and famous for its fabulous harbor, incredible beach front mansions and world class shopping. See where John Wayne, Humphery Bogart [sic], Tyrone Power, Buddy Ebsen and many of Hollywood's finest used to live. Today, Newport Beach continues to be the residence and playground to many sports celebrities, film and television stars and serves as the "on location" site for Fox Televisions [sic] hit series *The OC*.

Our tour began on the freeways as the bus made its way to the coast, accompanied by commentary from the tour guide (a long-time Orange Countian, possibly prone to exaggeration). Our first stop was a brief photo opportunity at a small park overlooking Newport Harbor, followed quickly by another short photo stop at the beach near Newport Pier. We proceeded to Balboa Pier and were dropped at kitschy, but not quite open yet, Balboa Fun Zone to spend an hour awaiting the start of our Harbor Cruise (Figure 74). The boat's captain was rather late to arrive, but as promised, we saw many oceanfront mansions and learned of notable persons who resided in them (Figure 75).



Figure 74. Balboa Fun Zone, as seen from the Harbor Cruise



Figure 75. View of Newport Harbor from the dock

After the cruise, we met back at the bus at the appointed time and our tour continued with a drive through the exclusive Newport Coast McMansion development (Figure 76). Although no one on the tour this day was a fan of *The OC* (except me) and thus no one on the tour could be considered a television-induced tourist, our tour guide did point out a couple of (very possibly fraudulent) filming locations from *The OC*. He even pulled the bus over so that we could get out to take a picture of a home supposedly used in the series.

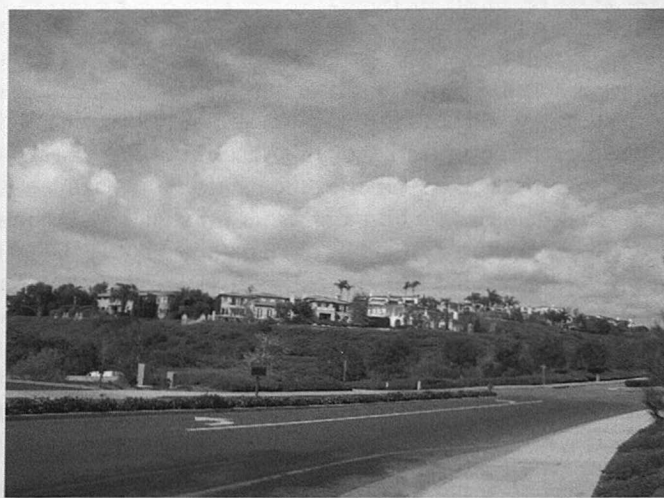


Figure 76. Newport Coast McMansions

Our final stop on the tour was Fashion Island Mall, a fancy indoor/outdoor shopping complex, at which we were dropped for at least two and a half hours.

The tour had arranged for our group to be greeted by the mall concierge, who presented us with a gift bag containing a nice souvenir coffee mug, perhaps to reassure us that our trip to the mall was somehow special. Upon getting back on the bus, one tour-taker commented to his wife and daughter that Fashion Island was just about like their mall back home, but with some more expensive stores (Figure 77).



Figure 77. Newport's Fashion Island Mall

I asked our tour guide about the frequency, in this post-OC period, of TV-induced tourists on the OC Experience tour and he replied that about half of his guests are fans of the show. He tells them "This is not *The OC*, but a tour of Orange County; otherwise you see a hospital, roads ... that's why I insert so much of myself into the tour ..." Underwhelmed by the Orange County experience I had just purchased, I understood the necessity of this disclaimer. For that day, Newport Beach lacked the magic that I and other of the media-influenced hoped the sights would evoke. Instead, it seemed a bit pathetic for our small, rather unenthusiastic group to be shuttled around on a large bus to take a few photos and go to the mall. Although the cruise was scenic and the mansion views impressive, overall, the tour provided a surface-skimming visit to what seemed to be a somewhat regular place. Newport may be the "crown jewel of the California Riviera" (Gray Line brochure) but even so, I never felt too far from the regular world of malls and freeways, motels and tourist traps of the unmediated Orange County. Several survey respondents who had visited Orange County felt the same way:

I didn't see too much of the glamour. It was pretty chill and I didn't see too many fancy houses or anything of the sort.

Not as many rich, gorgeous people walking around ... Lots of nice cars though in restaurant parking lots.

Much less lavish and more normal than what is shown on TV.

Way more traffic and cloudy gray weather.

Besides being more smoggy, I guess the people were more ugly and fat than in the shows.

Orange County cleaned up nicely for its prom photo. It's a beautiful place in real life, but not nearly as "perfect."

It is difficult, indeed, for a mere location to live up to the image presented by its mediated counterpart, especially when that place is televisual OC, an impossibly perfect beachfront setting which produces a powerful affect. Perhaps we are better off staying home, where televisual Orange County is safe from being "thinned out" by exposure to the hum-drum experience at a physical location. Televisual place derives its hyper-meaningfulness, or "excess of meaning" (BAUDRILLARD 1994, 28), and its charm from the stirrings of affect. Without TV's affect, we only get the location, which must become meaningful in different ways, through different processes.

This chapter has positioned "the OC" as a hyperreal simulation, providing a very stimulating, engaging, and affective experience of place which is only available through television. Touristic experience suggests that searching for televisual place in specific locations will likely end in disappointment. Regardless, beyond personal affect, televisual place produces powerful effects which resonate within greater Orange County.

CHAPTER 8

CONCLUSION: "RIGHT BACK WHERE WE STARTED FROM"

Well before the TV shows examined in this study aired, Orange County had given America its first theme park (Knott's Berry Farm) and its most famous (Disneyland), its first drive-in church (Robert Schuller's) and one of its biggest mega-churches (Saddleback). It supplies the U.S. Olympic team with athletes in events requiring copious amounts of sun and water: swimming, volleyball, softball, and water polo (REID 2008). It sports the newest of new towns, the most beautiful of beaches, and the most luxurious of shopping malls. Its mode of development is so emulated that there is now an Orange County, China full of "replicas of Southern California homes" built in the image of the American Dream, just north of Beijing (ROSENTHAL 2003) (Figure 78). Fittingly, SOJA (1996, 238) offers this description of the many wonders of Orange County:

... you can have *anything* you want in iconic Orange County, where every day seems just like yesterday but where the ever-present *Now*-ness of tomorrowland makes the *Then* hard to find; where every place is off-center, breathlessly on the edge, but always right in the middle of things, smack on the frontier, nowhere yet now/here like home. To its avid promoters, Orange County is a theme park-themed paradise where the American Dream is repetitively renewed and made infinitely available: as much like the movies as real-reel life can get. This resplendent bazaar of repackaged time and spaces allows all that is contemporary (including histories and geographies) to be encountered and consumed with an almost Edenic simultaneity.



Figure 78. Orange County, China

In the production and perfection of image, Orange County is unmatched. As SOJA (1996) intones, Orange County is as close to the hyperreal places on our TV and movie screens as an actual place can get. Indeed, *The OC*, *Laguna Beach*, and *The Real Housewives* would seem the perfect complement:

Perhaps more than any other place, more than the desert, more than either New York or Los Angeles, Orange County verifies Baudrillard's iconoclastic vision of the anesthetic enchantments of hyperreality. It is the generative utopia, a make-believe paradise that successfully makes you believe in make-believing, the most irresistibly California-looking of all the Californias, the most like the movies and TV "situation comedies," the most like the promised American Dream (SOJA 1996, 274).

Regardless of the magical qualities of its iconic built environment, "The OC" is much less diverse, much wealthier, and decidedly more dramatic than the Orange County that three-million-plus persons call home. No matter how enchanting the area might seem to a Disneyland guest from the Midwest in the winter, it also has traffic, poverty, and bland housing developments – all of the trappings of a regular life lived in postsuburban America. Although televisual Orange County and its locale provide vastly different experiences to visitors, "Orange County" is by no means exclusive of "the OC."

Recall how HANNA (1996) describes the relationship of television's Cicely to Washington's Roslyn. Roslyn's identity is bound up in its re-presentation as Cicely and all other representations that came before it. Just as televisual Cicely is now part and parcel of Roslyn, so "the OC" – the landscapes, emotions, and social spaces that comprise it – is an undeniable component of greater Orange County. Viewers cannot help but project the symbolic meaning and meaningfulness of televisual place onto it. Orange County, is always-already a "combination of the material and the mental and cannot be reduced to either" (CRESSWELL 1996, 13).

LIKE IT OR NOT ...

Residents of Laguna Beach and Coto de Caza uniformly complain to reporters about Orange County's television-induced image. Their comments reflect an acute awareness of how TV *is* reality. Laguna Beach, once a quaint art colony known for its thriving gay community, is fast becoming an affordable residence for only the super-rich, a transition *Laguna Beach* epitomizes and even exploits (SMITH 2005; BLY 2006; KELLY 2006). Opines one resident: "This is not depicting our town the way it should be depicted. Our town is about art and culture, and school should be about education" (STEINHAUER 2006). And another:

We are an affluent, tolerant community with a long heritage of culture, character, and art. The MTV show has hijacked our identity, and people are beginning to feel violated. It has become a metaphor for everything we don't want to be (BLY 2006).

Laguna's former mayor (then current), Cheryl Kinsman, chimes in on a more positive note: "I think [the show] will make us look more desirable. It could do for us what *90210* did for Beverly Hills. It will glamorize Laguna Beach" (RITCHIE

and ZLOTNIK 2004). These contradictory remarks speak to the broader socio-economic transition the region has undergone since the 1990s (see chapter three).

Local columnists who enjoy dishing on *The Real Housewives* express a general distaste within the Coto de Caza community for its newfound infamy:

This popularity is all much to the dismay of the residents of Coto de Caza, most of who just wish we were not associated with the self-indulgent, materialistic, and ridiculous people portrayed on the 'reality' show. I've got some bad news for those Coto folks – we're famous (SICKLER 2007a).

Since *The Real Housewives* has been on the air, most of the country has learned almost everything they know about [Coto de Caza] from the TV show. Which, for Coto residents, is really scary (SICKLER 2008).

Stephen SICKLER (2007b), a local columnist, describes a dinner conversation with Real Housewife Jeana:

"Jeana, most Coto residents really hate the show ... They think it makes all of us look so bad to everyone. One guy wants to start a class-action lawsuit for defamation of character." She shook her head in disbelief as her phone rang. Her husband was back in jail for drinking ... More reality to come.

In fact, *The OC*'s negative characterization of Chino ("Chino, ewww!" squeals a snobby Newport Beach teen upon learning Ryan's origin) and derogatory remarks made by its characters about neighboring Riverside (Wife: "He basically called me white trash. He said I was from Riverside!" Husband: "Honey, you *are* from Riverside.") have been perceived as so libelous to have prompted threat of litigation from a Riverside councilman (STRAIGHT 2003; LEDUFF 2005; VILLARREAL and POWERS 2006).

Travel literature also engages in playful attempts to separate Orange County from its memorable televisual counterpart, reinforcing the normative belief in representation. A headline in *National Geographic Traveler* for an article on Laguna Beach uses the opening line from *The OC*'s theme song and then discredits televisual place: "California, Here We Come: The Real 'OC': Never mind the television show. Orange County's much better in real life" (LIMSKY 2008, 147). A *Sunset Magazine* article, after quoting the lyrics to *The OC*'s theme song, informs readers:

Watch the show, and you'd think that Southern California's Orange County is a place where a new BMW, stylish clothes, and a surfboard ... are make-or-break necessities. Perhaps ... but there's more: secluded beaches, kid-friendly tide pools, even some fine art. And even a grommet (an inexperienced surfer) on a budget can experience what one fairly erudite California historian called "the last American paradise." And that's the real OC (LANSING 2004).

Finally, an ad placed by the Anaheim Orange County Visitor and Convention Bureau (slogan: "It's So California") reads: "Be swept away by our reality ... 42 miles of beautiful beaches, 4 seasons of warm weather, 1 real OC." The obvious effort to return ownership of the word "real" to the locale only further demonstrates how material and mediated place are utterly entangled, a revelation realized and embraced by county boosters.

Thanks to the truism "any publicity is good publicity," the "OC" moniker has recently popped up in several public venues, a direct result of the popularity of *The OC* and the name recognition it and the other shows have lent the county (LOWE 2008). There has been a push to incorporate "Orange County" into the name of the area's John Wayne Airport, and Dana Point Harbor has been redundantly rechristened "O.C. Dana Point Harbor." The Orange County Fair and Exposition Center has been renamed the OC Fair and Event Center. The inaugural OC Marathon was run in 2005 and for the second annual race, a cast member of *The OC* was given the honor of firing the starting gun (OVERLEY 2007; OVERLEY 2008; LOWE 2008). Most recently, the popular acronym has been bestowed upon several government agencies, including catchy changes from "Resources and Development Management" to "O.C. Infrastructure," "Integrated Waste Management" to "O.C. Waste and Recycling," and "Harbors, Beaches and Parks" to "OC Parks." Even *Beach Patrol*, a television show documenting "real" lifeguards, has been renamed *Ocean Force: Huntington Beach, OC* for the reason that "'the OC' is synonymous with drama" (GRIFFIN 2008). Residents continue to maintain, however, that "no one except tourists call Orange County 'the OC'" (LOWE 2008).

Of course, the county's tourism promoters are also putting the "OC brand" to good use. As Audrey LEONCIO (2008), a representative from the Newport Beach Convention and Visitors Bureau (NBCVB), explains:

[I]t's not really portraying us in the best light, [but] it's still capturing the overall essence of the destination. It's still showing the luxury ... and that's really how we market the destination ...

Representatives from the Anaheim/Orange County Visitor and Convention Bureau explain that "the show [*The OC*] launched us into a new place in the minds of consumers" (CALI 2008). "It's not just Disney, families, and Mickey, but a celebrity status destination filled with beautiful places and people" (CALI 2008). "We couldn't have paid for the exposure *The OC* has given us" (GALLAUGHER 2008).

The Orange County Tourism Council has recently undertaken a new regional branding effort which explicitly uses the term "the OC" and a logo which bears more than a passing resemblance to that of the TV show (Figures 79 and 80). This was a controversial decision, one not whole-heartedly supported by residents, but the tourism council felt they must take advantage of, and even embrace, the name recognition that the show has already provided (FEARY 2008). Says Gary Sherwin, head of the NBCVB, "What other part of the world has three reality shows that take place in it? I think we are really fortunate and need to try to capitalize on it" (OVERLEY 2008). These steps toward seducing tourists with "a fun-and-sun image made famous by Fox's *The OC* and a smattering of reality shows" (OVERLEY 2008) reinforce the fusion of the material and mediated as this singular image of place is projected worldwide. In the words of a Midwestern survey respondent: "The portrayal on TV comes from so many shows with similar themes, it's hard to

see [Orange County] any other way." In the end, Orange County is what it becomes on TV.



Figure 79. The OC logo

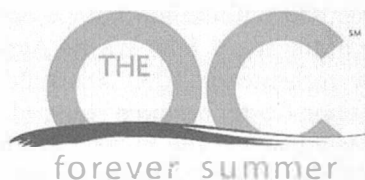


Figure 80. The Orange County Tourism Council logo

"THE SUN SETS ON THE OC"

It has now been seven years since *The OC* debuted and Orange County was introduced to America and the world. Since then, *The OC* has been cancelled, is in syndication worldwide (fans reside everywhere from Turkey to Norway to South Africa to Japan), and creator Josh SCHWARTZ' most recent television hit, *Gossip Girl*, is set in upper-crust, prep-school Manhattan (Figure 81).



Figure 81. Cast of *Gossip Girl* (2007)

Laguna Beach, after an unpopular third season, headed for *The Hills* (Figure 82). This spin-off reality drama follows *Laguna*'s main character, Lauren, to her young adult life in Los Angeles and became, in its own right, a pop cultural sensation. In one episode of *The Hills* (first aired December 8, 2008), Lauren nostalgically returns to Laguna Beach to help her parents move out of the extravagant home with party-ready patio, pool, and hot tub in which we saw her close her high school years. *The Hills*, in December 2008, spun off a duplicate series called *The City*, set in New York City (Figure 83).

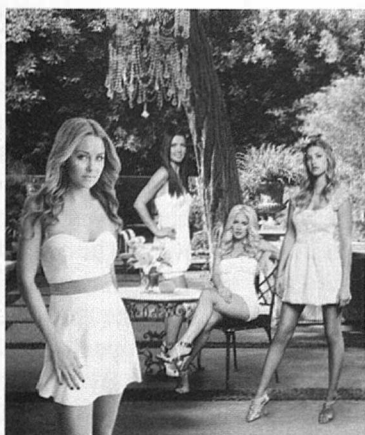


Figure 82. Cast of *The Hills* (2006)



Figure 83. Cast of *The City* (2008)

The Real Housewives of Orange County, in 2011, aired its sixth season, a much-anticipated return to the OC after the *Real Housewives* franchise expanded its coverage to wealthy and equally over-the-top ladies in New York City, Atlanta, New Jersey, Washington D. C., Beverly Hills, and Miami (Figure 84). In post-recession seasons five and six, several housewives face shrinking incomes and are scrambling to downsize their too-extravagant homes.



Figure 84. Cast of *The Real Housewives of New York City* (2008)

In a press release announcing *The OC*'s demise (titled "The Sun Sets on *The OC*"), SCHWARTZ eulogizes: "For a certain audience, at a certain time, *The OC* has meant something" (Fox 2007). Indeed it has.

PREVIOUSLY, IN THIS BOOK ...

This book is an exploration of televisual place and the processes of place-making through television. It has sought to establish the importance of mediated place as a meaningful experience of and in the world, as a "meeting place" (MASSEY 1994, 154).

Television employs several techniques which work together to create place – places carefully designed to seduce, engage, and affect viewers. The televisual place-making process begins with landscape. Each show commences, not immediately with narrative action, but by first setting the scene. The establishing shot and the montage of spectacular images which comprise the opening credits imbue a program with a sense of place and geographic realism. By describing place, these techniques are essential in encouraging the suspension of disbelief and audience interest in and subsequent enjoyment of the show. Moreover, these broadly-based landscapes – a beach which abuts a dramatic coastline, a golf course flanked by mansions – carry generic cultural meanings and naturalize stereotypes of the social geography of this place. These stereotypes and techniques guide viewers in their journey and emplace them within this hyperreal landscape.

During most of a show, however, landscape functions as a social space. Here landscape provides the spaces – in homes, restaurants, spas – within which the narrative unfolds. Within landscape, camera close-ups show characters' emotions, characters reveal their thoughts and feelings to each other, and characters move through the frame. It is within landscape as space that viewers are more deeply drawn into televisual place and engage with it.

These techniques work with and contra each other throughout a program to create televisual place. There is a continual tension between description and narration, between place and space. Social space is periodically interjected with symbolic landscapes (transitional shots) and these are repeated in each episode and throughout the series to reinforce and re-inscribe sense of place. On the other hand, although they tempt a voyeuristic desire to linger on the view, the forward movement of the narrative exerts a strong attraction, and these spectacular landscapes give way to narrative space. Week after week, as each show airs, viewers revisit this place and, through the portal of landscape, are further drawn into the world that television creates.

It is within narrative social space that we forge an emotional connection to televisual place. The elaborate storylines of melodrama (of which reality TV is also a part) may be unrealistic at face value, but viewers identify with the emotions they elicit. Pent-up feelings find expression in melodrama, and this emotional effect adds an essential dimension to our daily lives. This effect becomes affect as viewers integrate melodrama's emotional realism into their own emotional realities.

The melodramatic genre employs narrative conventions which operate within social space to assist in communicating emotional realism to audiences. Close-up shots of characters' facial expressions, as well as shots which linger on these faces

at the end of a scene, and importantly, the use of music, stir up viewers' emotions and affectively transport them to televisual place. Such intensities and sensations work to interweave a character's emotional journey with a viewer's subjectivity.

Televisual place is thus created through production techniques which foster geographic and emotional realism. During the course of a show, viewers continually move between gazing upon large-scale landscapes and emotionally participating in small-scale social space. The interplay of cultural meaning inscribed upon the TV world and the personal meaningfulness of direct experience within it comprises the televisual place-making process. But ultimately, this process is dependent upon viewer engagement.

Survey responses demonstrate several modes of engagement with televisual place. Often, viewers confront televisual place at a fictional level, which reinforces a strict distinction between the viewer's lived world and the world seen on TV. This viewpoint corresponds to a conceptualization of filmic place as a representation of reality. Many other survey respondents exhibit a subjective belief in, and partial acceptance of, the televisual world, indicating that television has changed their worldview. This belief is built upon generalized meanings and stereotypes which act to naturalize expressions of geographic realism and the social geographies presented on TV. These respondents distance themselves from the televisual world and are engaged in a thin form of place-making. Some respondents, however, possess an incorporative relationship with the televisual world, displaying an affective connection which effectively breaks the boundary of the real/reel dichotomy, allowing them to journey into televisual place. These respondents directly participate in televisual place-making; it is a meaningful experience with emotional value.

All of the techniques assembled in a television series work together to create and re-create a visual, emotional, and affective place of meaning and experience. This process constructs, builds, and reinforces place with each episode watched and enjoyed. Televisual place is thus a place like any other. It is a place that becomes personally meaningful, it is a meeting place which exists at the intersection of the multiple social processes that work to construct it, and it is a place that is experienced directly by its audience.

Televisual place, at the same time, is unlike any other. It is hyperreal in character and can provide a more stimulating, more engaging, and more fascinating experience than can be found in most any locale. The mechanisms which create televisual place produce a powerful affective response which captures both the senses and the imagination. So intense can be identification with these hyperreal televisual places that fans are often compelled to make a pilgrimage, to seek out the mythic, auratic "original," but tourists seeking televisual place are confronted with the paradox of two places sharing one location. Where they seek to nurture their psyche with the affective intensity of the hyperreal, they encounter an unmediated filming location which lacks affect. Televisual place is unreachable within everyday mundanity and cannot be defined by absolute location. Televisual place can only be found through the affective transport its production techniques provide.

From fast-growing defense industry suburb to planned community mecca and antithesis of LA, to recently starring in television as one of the most glamorous/notorious counties in the country, Orange County has always been an amalgam of mediated stereotypes and identities. Even before television elevated Orange County in the American and international pop-consciousness, it was, and always will be, a mediated place. *The OC*, *Laguna Beach*, and *The Real Housewives* have exerted a tremendous transformative impact upon the area's popular image, demonstrating that no place is wholly material.

More importantly, this trio of shows has contributed to the creation of a place called "the OC." The OC demonstrates that place cannot be restricted to a location, or even to an image on the screen; place is as much within ourselves. Place emerges as a process requiring active participation and is created as viewers connect with the televisual world. Televisual place transmits affective intensities and carries emotional registers that are part and parcel of meaningful experiences of, and in, the world. We must remember that mediated place—including the televisual—is not about the representation of one world, but the ongoing creation of many.

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